

A woman with dark hair tied back, wearing a black lace bodysuit, is shown from the waist up. She is holding a handgun in her right hand and looking over her left shoulder towards the camera. The background is a textured, blue-toned wall.

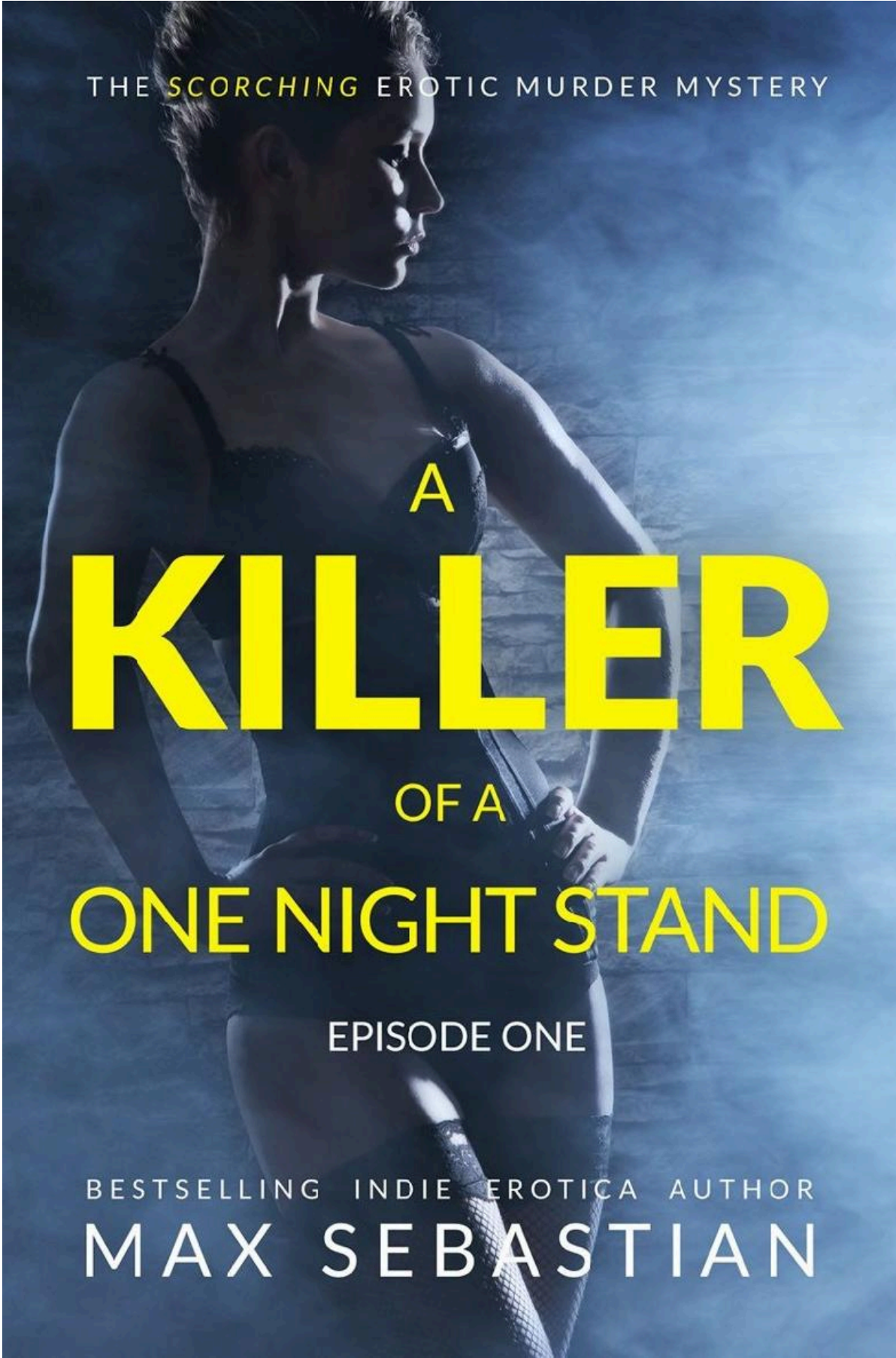
THE **SCORCHING** EROTIC MURDER MYSTERY

A
KILLER
OF A
ONE NIGHT STAND

EPISODE ONE

BESTSELLING INDIE EROTICA AUTHOR

MAX SEBASTIAN

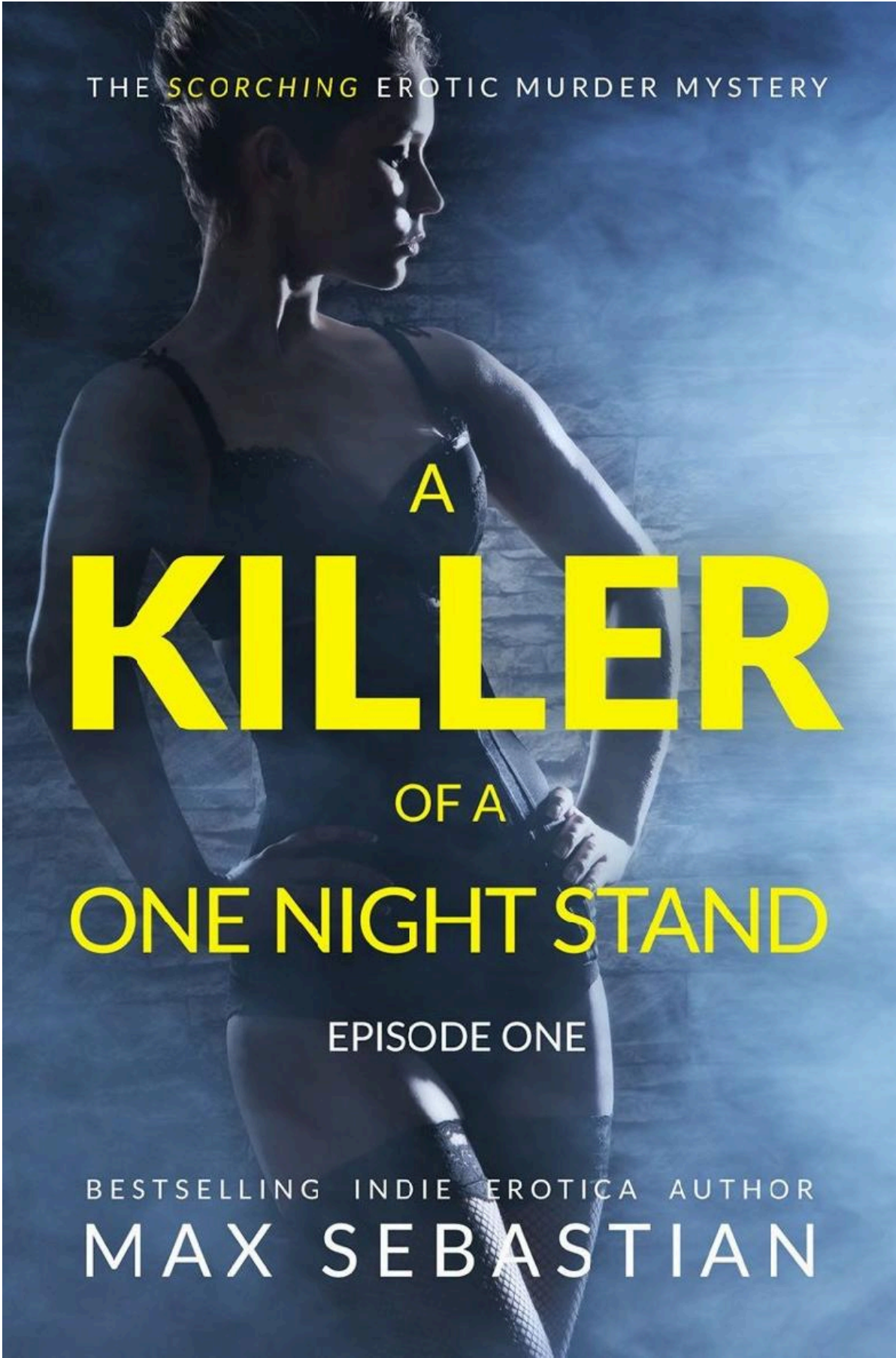


THE **SCORCHING** EROTIC MURDER MYSTERY

A
KILLER
OF A
ONE NIGHT STAND

EPISODE ONE

BESTSELLING INDIE EROTICA AUTHOR
MAX SEBASTIAN



THE **SCORCHING** EROTIC MURDER MYSTERY

A
KILLER
OF A
ONE NIGHT STAND

EPISODE ONE

BESTSELLING INDIE EROTICA AUTHOR
MAX SEBASTIAN

About the Author

Max Sebastian has written more than 20 novels, and regularly tops the bestseller lists for steamy erotic fiction. He began writing erotica at Literotica.com nearly two decades ago, and broke into the wider world of publishing in 2011.

Since then, Max has become well-known for sensual, steamy adventures in which couples explore thrilling alternatives to monogamous relationships, on their way to a very raunchy happy ever after—including menage stories, wife-sharing, hotwives, cuckolding and partner-swapping in various forms.

Max lives in London, England, and loves to hear from readers. Visit his website at www.maxsebastian.net.

Some of Max's Other Books

Web: MaxSebastian.net

[Anarchy of the Heart](#)

[Submitting to Her](#)

[The Madeleine Trilogy](#)

[What's Mine Is Yours](#)

[What's Yours Is Mine](#)

[The Game](#)

[She's a Star](#)

[Heidi, Corrupted](#)

[His Week With My Wife](#)

[Out of His League \(with Kenny Wright\)](#)

[Rock Her World](#)

[The One That I Married](#)

[Game Changer](#)

[Obsessive Trilogy](#)

[Marriage 2.0](#)

[A Lockdown Affair](#)

A Killer of a One Night Stand

Episode One

Max Sebastian

MAXSEBASTIAN.NET

Copyright © 2014 by Max Sebastian All rights reserved.

Cover Image © shmeljov | bigstockphoto.com

Second Edition published July 2021

No part of this book may be reproduced in any form or by any electronic or mechanical means, including information storage and retrieval systems, without written permission from the author, except for the use of brief quotations in a book review.

Prologue

London, after dark, mid-summer. He was nervous—he was always nervous doing this, no matter how many times he did it. So many things could happen, so many glitches, so many unexpected eventualities. And even if it all went completely to plan, he had no idea what to expect from the woman he was meeting.

He knew she'd be spirited, though. That was the point.

How must women feel, doing this? It takes two to tango, after all. Coming out to meet a stranger, it couldn't just be the men of the city, or nothing would ever happen in this particular field. Women doing this had to feel vulnerable. They had to be braver than the men.

Wasn't that what made these women so sexy, so thrilling? That they were bold, that they knew what they wanted. He'd always thought so.

London, a warren of dark streets. It was a smarter city than it had been a decade, two decades previously, but this was still the home of Jack the Ripper. And wandering along Brick Lane past the array of neon signs flagging up various curry houses, he knew this was right in the middle of the Ripper's Whitechapel territory.

Thinking about that, even more than a century after those murders, might make a guy nervous. A city like London, any sick bastard could just decide to start violating the sanctity of life—and perhaps, melt back into the teeming masses afterward, with no risk of discovery.

Men were not usually targets for such depraved individuals, though. And Brick Lane, with its multitude of young revelers and ethnic food enthusiasts, offered a kind of reassurance for someone coming out to meet a stranger.

He veered into the little open courtyard of the Vibe Bar, and there were enough people even on a weekday to provide a nice public meeting point.

He paused, searching the tables for the face who had haunted his dreams these past few weeks while they had built up to this very night. He found himself pleading with Fate that this woman was no fiction, no lie presented by an acne-infested teenage loser playing about with people's lives.

A quick search drew no hint of recognition. Perhaps she was late.

He moved on, up the little flight of steps into the bar itself, through a tiny entrance lobby plastered with event posters and past the tasteful graffiti marking the doors to the toilets, scanning the faces of the people milling about in the dark interior, those slumped in the big easy chairs or the seats around tables. Still nothing. A drink would settle his nerves, give him something to do while waiting. He was wearing the charcoal suit, white shirt, black tie, just as agreed—

she could find him once she arrived.

“Martin?”

A middle-aged man. His heart sank, immediately jumping to the conclusion that his date had been made-up. You could never entirely guarantee this wouldn't happen.

"Yes," he said, with a little sigh. Thinking, even worse: this could be the husband. She'd never said anything about a husband, but that didn't mean anything.

"She wanted me to find you, make sure you are who you say you are."

If he was the husband, he didn't seem angry.

"Well, I think I am. Is she here?"

"She's staying at the Hilton."

"The one by Tower Bridge?"

"The one on Park Lane."

Immediate question on his mind: why tell him to meet in Brick Lane? Proximity to the husband's workplace, perhaps. Suitable distance to the wife's hotel room in order to give her time to escape if her date was a bad egg.

The husband, if that was who he was, was looking him over—subtly, but he was looking him over. Making sure he was acceptable?

"What time is she expecting me?"

"You have plenty of time. You'll need this."

A plastic card in a little envelope—a hotel room key. It was mildly amusing, being made to chase across London for his night of passion. The Hilton, though, that would make it quite something.

He took it, and the husband gave him a look that appeared thankful. He probably wasn't imagining the hint of sadness in those eyes, though. He'd never fully understand a husband who was complicit—and perhaps even behind—his wife's infidelity, why the guy would want to give himself that kind of heartache.

But there was no question, the wife of such a man was often something special in bed.

He found himself walking to the Tube station of Liverpool Street Station via Fournier Street, which took him past the Ten Bells, the Victorian pub that always gave him the shivers because of its association, whether fact or fiction, with the Ripper victims.

As he past it, it was busy to overflowing with suited City traders, a step up in class compared to the ladies of the night who frequented the place in the Ripper's day, if not a step up in moral standards.

He had his own lady of the night waiting for him, now, in the luxury Hilton hotel over by Hyde Park. The potential had his heart racing already.

Married pussy. Well, that was the point of all this, wasn't it? Easy sex, no commitment, and a woman driven to desperation by the inevitable settling of a marriage.



"S how it to me."

"Yes, Miss."

The redhead was just standing there, watching him with vague disdain on her face as he unhitched his belt and dragged down his suit pants. But he could tell this was a thrill for her.

The way her eyes lit up as he revealed his manhood confirmed it.

"Mmm... okay," she said, "it's acceptable."

She grabbed him, her fingers squeezing him a touch more brutally than was ideal, though his cock responded to that, throbbing in her hand. She hadn't even kissed him yet.

He opened his shirt, and saw that she clearly found his toned chest acceptable, too.

“Did I tell you you could take off your shirt?”

“No, Miss.”

“You want to watch yourself. You don’t do anything unless I say so.”

“No, Miss.”

She curled a hand around his neck, and then stroked it down over his collarbone, his pecs and that washboard of a stomach, her other hand beginning to gently coax his stiff shaft.

What a picture, standing there in her black lingerie, complete with lace-topped stockings.

“Kiss me here,” she said, pointing to her cleavage, her hand never leaving his cock as he complied with her command, burying his face in the smooth, hot flesh of her breasts. Breathing in her sweet fragrance as he kissed her exactly where she told him to.

“Get down on your knees.”

He instantly complied, kneeling by the bed.

“Show me how much you love me,” she said, lifting up one of her legs, placing her foot in its sharp stiletto shoe on the pristine bed sheet beside him.

He leaned forward, pressing his nose to the black netting covering the top of her foot, kissing her softly before sliding his face slowly up her shin, marveling at the shape of her leg, the graceful curves of her calves, her thighs.

These dates were anything but guarantees, but tonight he’d struck gold.

“You like that? You like being down there?”

“Yes, Miss.”

“Move on up.”

He drew in her sexy scent as he slid his face up over her knee, over that band of luxurious lace, his hand touching the bare flesh above the top of her stocking, reveling in the smoothness of her skin, the heat of her body.

He could detect that darkness beneath her perfume, the aroma of her sex, as he slowly kissed his way along her thigh.

He heard her breathing deepen, knew she was desperate for him to worship her, though she was good at controlling her urges. But he teased her, kissing his way up to the edge of her panties, then moving away, once, twice, three times, indulging himself in her smell, the glimpse of her sex he could get through the black lace of her panties, the searing heat that promised so much.

She wasn't going to be teased for long, however. He felt her hand grab the back of his head, forcing him to her, pressing his face to her crotch so that his lips and nose were crushed against the damp lace, swamped by her heat.

"Do it," she ordered, and he nuzzled into her, opening his lips to press his hot mouth to her through her underwear. "Oh God, that's it..."

He tilted his head to more effectively lick her through the black lace, loving how

wet she was already, loving that it was him making this gorgeous creature be that way.

Was she a goddess in real life? Who could tell if the story she'd shared with him over dinner was the truth? The truth was completely unnecessary on these dates, except for the central truth of two people being attracted to one another.

"You smell that?" she pulled his head against her heat again, asserting herself over him. "It's good, huh? Nice sweet pussy. Oh, you like it..."

She seemed confident enough to be a regular at this, but the extent of her arousal suggested to him that she didn't get to be this way at home.

"Take them off," she breathed.

He reached up to peel the skimpy little thing down from her waist, revealing more of her smooth skin, that cute v-shape camber down to the gentle purple-pink petals of her womanhood.

She was so perfect. Truly worth worshipping.

“Now, lie down.”

He could see her tender folds glistening with her moisture, and it made his mouth water. He wondered if she was the kind of woman who could really embrace a man’s hunger. So far she’d suggested she was, but having him lie there on his back, his flagpole waving in the air-conditioned air of this comfortable hotel room, there was a danger she was going to deprive him of his apéritif.

He lay, obediently, and allowed her to wander slowly around the bed, appreciating the form of his tamed flesh. He kept himself in good order. These encounters were the high point of his week, there was no way he was going to allow for the disappointment of a woman disapproving of him physically.

She climbed up on the bed now, moving like a panther over the enormous mattress, straddling his hips, her eyes blazing as her wetness touched down on his hard shaft.

“You must work out a lot,” she said, prodding his right bicep, pressing her hot

pussy down against his cock, sliding her slippery lips up and down his length, grinding against him without allowing him to slip inside her. Grazing her clit on his cock.

“Yes, Miss.”

“Perhaps even a little too much,” she said, and he wasn’t sure he entirely understood where she was coming from, but he could hardly question her.

Now she shifted up his body, and lifted a shapely leg, and he felt that little tickle of excitement at knowing what she meant to do.

“I’d say you probably work out so much, you’re quite impressed with yourself, aren’t you?” she said, and now she was kneeling over his head,

her soaking pussy just inches from his eager mouth.

“No, Miss,” he lied.

“I don’t believe you for a second,” she said, edging down, knowing the effect she was having on him.

She was so beautiful, her pussy flushed with blood, her lips slippery with her dew, but she didn’t give it to him just yet. She froze, with perfect poise and control, merely allowing him to look at her and inhale her heavenly bouquet with each breath, but not taste her as he wanted. If he could tear his eyes away from her exquisite flower, he could see her sweet topography, the elegant v-shape of her abdomen, the taut stomach, the delicious rise of her breasts, the way her nipples strained against the lace of her bra.

He craned his neck, but she moved it out of his way, offering him a warning glare.

What was she doing? Reaching underneath the pillows. What did she have there? When had she put it there?

Instant recognition as the handcuffs glinted in the yellow light from the bedside lamps. Kinky. Without waiting to be told, he put his arms up, positioning his hands up by the headboard to allow her to shackle him.

She didn’t comment on his acting before he was told. Allowed him his preemptive obedience.

Only when she was satisfied he wasn’t getting out of those cuffs did she seem to relax, and allowed him his reward, slumping down, her knees spreading further beside his ears to allow her to touch down on his mouth.

She tasted divine.

He loved how she pressed herself down over him, his world swamped by the heat and musk of her intimate core. How she happily used him, shimmying her hips to brush her pussy over his lips and tongue, fucking his face.

“Oh yeah... oh yeah...”

She rode him, her pace accelerating, telling him at one stage to put his tongue out so she could fuck him. She gripped the pillow behind his head and really rocked his world.

“...you like me using you like that?...”

The way she smothered him, he could sometimes hardly hear what she was saying, but the snippets he could hear lit the torches within him. She was a dirty girl, perhaps something she normally had to repress. But then these dates had always offered the potential to be liberating in that way if you embraced them.

Allowed you to explore your inner feelings, even if you never knew you had them.

She held onto the top of the headboard and flexed her hips as though she was riding a horse in the Derby.

“...God, your face was made for a girl to fuck...”

But she did not allow herself to come. She showed the kind of control that women on these dates rarely did, from his experience.

She wanted his cock inside her, bareback, he could sense it.

She dismounted, the sudden loss of her body heat and the exposure of his soaking face to the cool air gave him a sudden chill as he lay there panting for breath. What was she doing?

He looked down, saw her fumbling at the foot of the bed. She grabbed his ankle, and he felt the hard steel enclose it. More cuffs. It made him smile. She was a kinky one. She wanted him completely helpless.

He smiled as she shackled his other foot as well, leaving him spreadeagled on the bed.

Then she was stuffing something black and lacy in his mouth, and he knew from the flavor of the damp fabric it was her panties she was using as a gag. So be it.

Kinky bitch.

Bring it on.

The blindfold was a surprise, but he accepted it. The blackness allowed him to focus on his other senses, indulge in the scent of her lingering wetness on his face, the feeling of her smooth skin, her hot flesh as she climbed onto him once again. The silky sounds of her body moving against his, as she straddled him, clutching his cock, positioning it before plunging down on it.

God, she was so tight around him. Her pussy was truly magnificent. He was not going to last long.

She was silent now. That was a little different. She'd been so vocal before. Well, what was she going to say? She could hardly order him to do anything—he was completely bound. He could pump his hips, but she controlled the motion as she fucked him.

He could hear her deep breathing, that was all. She had even stifled the moans he knew she'd ordinarily be making, judging by the sounds she'd made riding his face.

Was she even going to tell him he could come?

He groaned, indicating to her that unless she let up, he was going to lose it very soon. She didn't get the message, or at least, didn't alter her pace. She was relentless, using him again, in that wonderfully dominant way.

He could feel himself coming to the end, throbbing powerfully within her, getting to the point of no return. If he wasn't with such a dominant woman, he might ordinarily stop at this point, calm himself, perhaps focus on her pleasure

for a while if she'd let him, until he was ready for more himself once again.

Right now, though, there was no choice.

He groaned through the balled-up panties filling his mouth, warning her. She did not stop.

If anything, her pace intensified, her pussy squeezing his shaft like a vice.

Oh God. He was about to come.

It was so intense, so extreme. He could feel it building inside his loins, his manhood feeling so immense squeezed by this siren's exquisite sex, pulsating as the switch suddenly flipped and he was pumping deep inside her.

And she was having just as incredible an experience it seemed, he could feel her writhing and thrashing about on top of him. Hear her screaming with what seemed almost like rage as she came with him, her body shuddering over him, shaking as though she was possessed by some kind of tormented spirit.

Then suddenly she thumped his chest incredibly hard, as though trying to restart his heart, except there was a ferocious stinging, burning sensation—and he felt something thrust into his chest, something hard and intensely cold.

Another thump, and strangely it was her hissing roar of anger that really terrified him, rather than the pain of his chest being pierced or the realization that this was no kinky sex game any more.

That murderous, evil clamor coming from her mouth. Bloodcurdling.

In the brief moments he had left, he felt surprise that there wasn't more pain, that the blade felt so cold sinking into him, that there really was no protection for him, that this was the end, there was nothing after this for him, his life would simply be extinguished, and the world would continue to turn without him in it.

There was nothing he could do. He was completely shackled, at her mercy.

And she had no mercy.

One

Waiting outside Covent Garden Tube station, Jonah Fielding was more nervous than he'd ever been in his life, and it made him realize just how sheltered his life had been up until this point. He felt light-headed, even a little nauseated, from the anticipation, the uncertainty.

He still had time to escape. Only his date would ever know, and she wasn't in a position to do anything about his cowardice if he wasn't there when she arrived.

He could dart away down a back-street, jump on a bus, grab a taxi. Might even get away with sneaking into the very same Tube station his date would soon be emerging from, if he was lucky. It would be so very simple to just get out of here

—never mind the expensive hotel room he'd booked.

Nathan would forgive him, but there would always be that little twinge of disappointment, no doubt, knowing that his brother had taken the easy route again.

He would show him. If Nate could do this, so could he. He would make his brother proud that he was challenging the boundaries of his safe little life.

He was visibly trembling as he stood there in the crowd hovering outside the station exit. Clapsed together in front, his pale hands were clammy, sweaty. He tried drying them on his pants, worried that the girl would laugh at him after shaking his hand for the first time.

Maybe she wasn't even coming. Maybe she would have second thoughts.

No, she had done this before. She'd be here.

Emma. Might be her real name, might not. Chances were it probably wasn't, since this was the game they were playing. Jonah was going under the name

“Robert”—a nice, clean name that any City boy could have. His usual faded old clothes had become a sharp, designer suit. His overlong, unkempt hair was now shorter, slicked back.

Would she believe he was a City boy?

Emma. Pretty, according to her picture, though those could be easily faked.

Blonde, shoulder-length hair, five foot two, slim, long legs, small but “pert”

breasts—so said her profile. Looking for no-strings-attached sex with a brash stockbroker or banker, or a slick corporate lawyer at the outset. Not the kind of girl that shy academic Jonah Fielding would ever mix with in a social situation.

Jonah wondered if he’d bitten off more than he could chew. The hotel key card jabbed him in the thigh, almost taunting him. Did people really do this? Did people really select strangers for sex like this?

Maybe he should have practiced a little first, done something easier as a way to dip his toe in before taking the big plunge. He could have done some ordinary online dating, or even answered an ad in the newspaper personals page. Perhaps he was stupid to be going straight for it like this. If he seemed nervous, perhaps she’d realize he wasn’t what he’d said in his profile. Perhaps she’d leave her drink untouched and excuse herself to the restroom, then slink away while he wasn’t looking. The hotel room he’d booked between Leicester Square and Piccadilly Circus would remain unused that night.

Another batch of people were coming out of the large elevator and through the station’s ticket barrier. Was she among them?

He took a deep breath, holding his nerve and his position. He had to do this. It wasn’t just for kicks, he had a purpose here. Nate would forgive his beloved brother for chickening out, but there would always be the regret that he wasn’t quite brave enough to do what was necessary. A question forever hanging over him, a doubt over his commitment to his brother.

He had to do it.

What kept him rooted to the spot just then was the thought that failure would mean returning, dejected, to that ghastly apartment, knowing he had not done his best.

To the outsider, it was a plush apartment, spotless in appearance so that Jonah could put it on the market. But to him, it was a place tinged with the memory of Nate. His brother had had so many good times at that

place during his days in London, some of which they'd shared together. Now, it just reminded him of

what had disappeared.

The loss, the massive piece of him that was now gone, compelled him to jump outside his comfort zone. To meet this girl on a dark London street. To retrace his brother's steps, and edge a little closer to identifying the woman who had killed Nate on a date just like this one.



It wasn't exactly easy to check every single face coming out of the station.

Maybe she'd come out already, maybe she was also waiting here somewhere on this pedestrianized street, waiting for him. There were a lot of people here, waiting, walking by, watching the buskers and the street magicians or peering at A-Z guides or smartphones, seeking the next place to go.

For a second, he relaxed, thinking she had stood him up. As bruising to his ego as that might be, it would be easier.

Then he caught sight of a face in the crowd that he recognized. Pretty, shoulder-length bell of blonde hair, waiting for sex. Sex with him. Or at least, sex with some City boy called "Robert" who happened to have a profile picture that resembled him.

Her eyes looked down the moment he spotted her, watching where she was putting her feet, not wanting to stumble at such a time. Then she looked up, and he was doubly certain it was her. Such amazing eyes. Seeing her, recognizing her, watching her face as she reacted to the identification of his own features, it felt like a nuclear device had exploded inside his stomach. God.

Too late to turn back now, she was walking towards him as his own treacherous feet kept carrying him closer.

Why had he gone straight into this? He wasn't ready to use this matchmaking service for one night stands. For no-strings, no-questions-asked, shockingly abrupt sex. He was doing it because his brother's own date, using this very service, had been the last thing he'd spoken to Nate about, just a few hours before it. So attempting to practice through any other service other than the "No Strings" website would seem like the long way round.

Emma smiled at him as she approached, and he hoped it was because she perceived him to be the City boy he'd claimed: stylish threads, combed hair. Not a flaky academic currently putting the finishing touches to his doctoral thesis.

Pretty, oh so pretty. Emma.

His eyes were getting more accustomed to the light levels, and for a moment the crowd parted and he was afforded a glimpse of her petite figure. She hadn't lied.

The advice on the website forum suggested that you didn't do anyone any favors if you did lie, but somehow he still expected that if she'd turned up, she would be plain at best.

Emma was stunning in her little figure-hugging black dress, her legs clad in scandalous—and faintly rebellious-looking—fishnets. He couldn't believe someone like this had picked him out to meet for sex.

"Hi, you must be Robert, nice to meet you," she said, and reached up to kiss his cheek. He caught a lung-full of her perfume, which was sweet and a little exotic, with perhaps a hint of coconut.

"Yes, hi," he said, trying to sound confident, trying to sound like a stockbroker or a currency dealer or some such. "Sorry, it's probably not the best place to meet. So crowded."

Oops. Shouldn't have apologized. The chauvinistic banker or stockbroker or corporate lawyer wouldn't apologize. "Robert" wouldn't care if he made life difficult for his date.

"It's okay, I found you," she smiled. "You fancy a drink?"

"Of course."

She took his arm in hers, her flesh so smooth and so warm it surprised Jonah. He felt strangely light-headed as they walked off towards the wide, safe plaza of Covent Garden and a nearby bar—the job interview for them both to make sure neither was a psychopath before they eloped to that hotel room.

God, did this girl really want to sleep with him? Could he go through with it?

It would be more embarrassing to pull out of the deal, now.

“You’re quite quiet,” she said a few steps further on.

“I’ve... uh... I’ve never actually done this before,” he said. His honest tongue ruining the whole charade.

Still, a City boy had to start somewhere.

“A virgin?” she joked, affectionately squeezing his arm. “So to speak.”

“Well, you know...”

“I’ll go easy on you, I promise.” Then, perhaps worried he would think her some kind of amateur call-girl, she added: “I’ve only done this a few times before, you know—and it’s been a while since the last time.”

She already seemed too nice to be a murderer. Looks could be deceiving, of course.

He said, “It’s quite strange meeting you like this.”

“For a one-night stand?” she laughed, and it was suddenly out there. They were going to have a one night stand.

“Yes. I mean, it’s great, but...”

“...but you wouldn’t expect a nice girl like me to have sex with a stranger like this?”

She looked up at him with an impish grin.

“I guess so,” he said, feeling his “Robert” persona crashing down in flames.

“That’s part of the fun,” she said, “doing things you ordinarily wouldn’t do.

Come on, let’s get some booze down our throats.”

She grabbed his hand and pulled him into the Porterhouse, a large, popular multi-level pub on Maiden Street, just around the corner from Covent Garden itself.

In the dark confines, they wove their way down various steps, squeezing through the crowd to the bar. Jonah thought he could easily have slipped away in this place. She’d never know. Emma couldn’t be a killer, despite her apparent need to do things she ordinarily wouldn’t do. Continuing this one night stand would be a waste of time, wouldn’t it?

What would Nate think? What would Nate do? He’d say, enjoy yourself, little brother, just enjoy yourself for once.

Well, he couldn’t be 100 percent sure she wasn’t a killer, nice as Emma appeared to be. Chances were she wasn’t, of course, though he had to try. And all this would be useful practice for the next time. The more practice he had, the less anxious he’d be about the dating, and the more chance he’d pick up on the signs when he did eventually track down the woman who killed Nate.

And if he found the killer and missed those warning signs, he could very well end up dead himself.

As Emma ordered drinks, not even asking him what he wanted, he thought to himself that his “Robert” act was not surviving. But, then again it was possible that a real “Robert” would allow the little lady to do the hard work of procuring the alcohol, while he merely stood back. Besides, being attractive and female, she was served a heck of a lot quicker than he probably would have been.

Two glasses in one hand, bottle of red in the other, she grinned at him and flicked her head to suggest they move upstairs.

Jonah grabbed the bottle from her, lightening her load, and again followed her through the throng to the stairs. Emma went in front as they climbed to the second floor, so that he couldn't do anything but admire how her dress clung to her curves and her cute little behind, he couldn't help running his eyes all over her shapely thighs, clad in those dangerous-looking fishnet stockings.

Could he really have some of that tonight?

Somehow, they found a small table hidden away in a shady corner, timing it just right as another couple was leaving.

As they settled, the first thing she said, rather businesslike, was: "Do you have your papers?"

She pushed an unfolded sheet of paper across the table, and Jonah caught a quick glimpse of the title, "Medical certificate", before realizing what she was getting at.

"Uh—yeah," he said, blushing as he retrieved his own doctor-approved permission slip, as required by the website.

She peered for a moment at his test results, which he'd been so embarrassed to

get from his GP with a faltering cover story about needing it to get married abroad.

"So, that's done," she said with an easy smile, the formality seeming to leach out of her petite frame. "A little awkward, huh."

"Yes," Jonah returned her smile as they returned their papers to each other.

"So you're married?" she asked him as he poured wine for them both. "I know you didn't really say in your profile—"

She had a rapid-fire manner of speaking, betraying her excitement at this strange game in which they were now immersed. He liked it—though some men might not—he found it attractive. Both the suggestion that she was intelligent, and also the sense that she was genuinely excited about the possibility of becoming intimate with him.

He answered her honestly, “No, I’m not married.”

Her eyes doubted him. “You can tell me, I mean, that is what all this is usually about.”

“Usually?”

She looked at him, amused at his apparent naivety. “You do know it’s a website for married people to... you know... see other people?”

Jonah felt completely taken aback—had Nate known this? He’d never said anything about married women.

“Right, but... you know...”

She nodded. “Nobody usually talks about that side of things, right. I’m sorry, I suppose you could say... I have a bit of a mouth.”

That made him smile.

“You like married men?” he asked her.

She shrugged, “Not particularly. Thought I would, thought they’d be more

mature. I guess I’ve only been with a few so far, that told me, anyway. Older, more experienced. A touch on the desperate side, though, some of them.”

“I’m sorry—I suppose I’m not massively experienced at this,” Jonah said, knocking back his wine like it was some kind of antidote to the raw anxiety flowing through his veins.

He still couldn’t believe this girl was intending to go back to his hotel room later.

She was sitting back a little, her legs crossed, her short dress allowing him to see some way up her trim thighs, so that he thought he could just about see the tops of her fishnet stockings.

“Might be nice for a change,” she said, swirling her own wine in her glass before sniffing the bouquet. “I’m normally the young innocent, taking

orders...”

Jonah poured more wine for them both, not really meaning it as any kind of comment, but she let out a self-conscious laugh, adding: “Look at me, making myself sound like I’ve been on hundreds of these things.”

“Not at all,” he said.

He realized that he was beginning to lose his way in questioning her—diverting from his prime objective for being there. He needed to dig a little more before their time ran out. Even if she seemed too nice to be the murderer, he had to try.

He needed to practice and perfect his interrogation patter in case he ever did meet the one he was really seeking.

But where to begin? What kind of questions would flush out a heartless murderer?

“So you normally go for older guys? Older than me?”

“On this thing,” she said, referring to the website, “always. Never tried anyone within even five years of my own age. Guess I liked your picture.” A smile, perhaps relieved that his picture hadn’t turned out to be fake.

“And you’re, what, twenty-five, twenty-six?”

“Twenty-two. I didn’t lie in my profile—unlike most people, I suppose.”

“You seem older,” he realized it wasn’t a compliment for a woman, and quickly added, “I mean more mature for your age.”

“And was your profile accurate?” she asked, looking at him as though it wouldn’t matter to her if it was all fiction, as much of it was.

“I am definitely twenty-seven,” he said.

“You’re the youngest I’ve tried, by far. I guess you have a nice smile in your picture.” She grinned, and he tried to stop himself from blushing. If true, her answer would rule her out from being Nate’s killer. But if she was the killer, would she feel any need to speak the truth?

He felt some regret that he had to lie to her. She had to be expecting it to some degree—when she was going with married men, for example.

“This is really your first time on one of these?” she asked him.

“Yeah. Is that a problem?”

“No, no. At least, I don’t think so,” she peered at him across the little table.

Leaning in for a closer look. “You’re not going to chicken out on me, are you?”

He felt the fire stoked in his belly at that. “Uh... no. No.”

“Good,” she grinned mischievously, then took another sip of wine. “Kind of hot, don’t you think? We’ve never met before—I don’t know anything about you, you don’t know anything about me. But we can just get out of here and fuck like rabbits.”

“I guess that’s the whole point.”

“So, you have a room booked somewhere?” she sipped her wine while gazing into his eyes, a gaze so filled with lust that it nearly knocked him sideways.

“Uh, yeah,” he said, desperately trying to think of something to say. Nerves always made him freeze up, but now he was worried that no matter how keen Emma seemed on the idea of taking him back to his hotel room, she could still get bored of him in the mean time. He added: “The Thistle. Just off Leicester Square.”

“Not bad. Nice and close.”

“So,” he said a little lamely, but warming up, he hoped. “What happens next?”

“Next?”

“I’ve never done this before...”

Emma shrugged again. Was he losing her? She said, “Well, we’re probably meant to find out a little more about each other—you know, before.”

He was losing her, he could see the energy draining out of her face. He was so useless at this. Bloody academic. He knew he should be a little more forward with her. She was leading the conversation at the moment, but a City boy would want to take control. He needed to practice his “Robert” persona if he wanted to be more confident with it, it was so difficult to break through that natural reserve of his.

Emma reached forwards to refill his glass before her own, saying: “Shouldn’t give you too much more of this, I suppose.”

“No, it’s all right,” he said, trying to put a bit more life into his voice.

“Don’t want you collapsing on me when we get to the hotel,” she rolled her eyes, which suggested to Jonah that it was something that had happened to her before.

And, perhaps helped by the wine now, he found his Robert-persona making a play, saying to her: “I’m sure once I’ve got that dress off you, I’ll have no trouble in that particular department.”

She positively beamed at that, from the compliment and the fact that he was making an effort to get into this.

With a sly glance either side to see if anyone was close enough to hear them, she said in a hushed voice: “Have you got a big one? You know, a big... cock?”

Their little corner was surprisingly private for such a crowded pub, but her blunt question made him look again to make sure no one else could hear. It quite took his breath away.

Then, she added: “Not that it really matters to me, of course. There are benefits either way.”

Feeling rivulets of adrenaline streaming through his bloodstream as he stepped past his usual boundaries, he drained the remaining few mouthfuls of wine, and said: “I’m sure I’ve got enough where it counts to keep you happy.”

Emma beamed at him again. Right answer. She said: “Had to ask.”

Jonah smiled, feeling the tension between them thawing a little. Willing his confidence to come out, trying to channel his “Robert” character, he said, “Do you think if I had a small one, I’d really fess up before I got you back to my hotel room?”

“I can usually tell when people lie to me.”

“So you know I’m telling the truth?” He said, trying to rest on the fact that he had avoid actively lying to her so far, although he wasn’t telling her his whole story.

“About that,” she said, her blue eyes flickering as she looked him over. “Sure.”

There was a slight pause as Emma took another gulp of her drink, and Jonah topped them both up from the bottle. Then he felt himself asking a question without really thinking about it: “Do you get nervous going off with strange men?”

It was more of a “Jonah” question than a “Robert” question—genuinely curious, rather than brashly seeking sex. The academic in him slipping out, he supposed.

She put down the glass and hit the ball back at him: “Strange men like you?” She grinned, “I guess I’m quite nervous. I had a glass or two of vino before I came out. It’s pretty exhilarating, though, too. Isn’t it? Not knowing what it might be like.”

“It could be pretty dangerous.”

“With you, or in general?”

They both chuckled, and Jonah accepted that she probably thought him pretty

tame. Feeling he had nothing to lose, he said: “I’ll bet I’m pretty tame compared to some of your past encounters.”

She tilted her head, looking him up and down. “I don’t know yet. Are you tame?”

“Maybe, compared to some people. Not compared to others.”

“I don’t think I’ve ever been out with someone tame.”

“You like it rough?” he asked, and felt himself blushing again.

“I like it all sorts of ways,” she said, that twinkle back in her eyes.

She leaned forward, and beckoned with her finger for him to do likewise.

Drawing close to her, he breathed in her sweet fragrance, which stepped up the pace of his heartbeat. He wasn’t quite sure if she wanted to whisper something to him, or kiss him.

Gazing into his eyes, she reached out to pull him further towards her, and it turned out to be a kiss that she was after.

Her lips were so soft, and syrupy sweet, while tinged with that slight bitterness from the wine. He felt the noise level in the room dip as she pulled him to her to explore his lips, her tongue dipping gently inside his mouth in what seemed to be an intimate and somehow explicit manner.

How strange it was to be kissing someone so soon after meeting them.

It was his inner sheltered academic reacting with such shock, but he couldn’t quite believe that other people came together like this, without the weeks of terrified flirtation that his encounters with the opposite sex usually involved.

His breath almost used up, Emma eventually broke away from him, and withdrew to her seat as though nothing much had just happened.

“Not bad,” she said, picking up her wine glass and swirling it around. Her nonchalant tone felt like a dagger in his chest. Then she looked up at him and smiled again, saying: “Actually, that was pretty special.”

Relief flowed through his veins as she added: “I think I could go for a tame guy, if he kisses like that.”

“Maybe I could convert you,” he suggested.

Then she leaned forward again, looking side to side to check no one was watching, and signaled for him to do likewise once again. She kissed him again, trying to sample him like a fine wine. He gave as good as he got, though this time he brought his hand up behind her head, his fingers running through her silky blonde hair for the first time.

“God!” she said, breathless as they parted this time, and gave him a look of genuine surprise. “Are you sure you work in the City?” she asked—a question that almost made him splutter as he sipped his wine.

He didn’t know if he could answer, but thankfully she didn’t seem to be demanding one, treating her own question as rhetorical.

“So is there anything you want to know about me?” she asked instead. “I mean

—before we, you know...”

“I... uh...” he said, drinking more wine as he failed to come up with something.

“Guys don’t really need to know much, do they?” she chuckled. “They’ll pretty much go for whoever, huh.”

“So girls only need to know how big the guy’s cock is?” he threw it back at her.

She raised her eyebrows, “Touché.”

“As long as you don’t have a cock,” he said, “I’m happy enough to find things out along the way.”

Hopefully, though, he wouldn’t find that she was a murderer. He wasn’t really ready for that yet, despite his resolve. Didn’t know what he would do.

“Fair enough,” the pretty blonde nodded, looking suddenly serious—perhaps because he did. She couldn’t keep it up for long, giggling: “I don’t, by the way.

Have a cock, I mean.”

He smiled, and she added: “You can check, if you’d like.”

“Hmm, I’d like that,” he said.

Their bottle finished, Emma suggested a nightclub she knew nearby. Jonah was unsure, but the fear creeping over him as the clock ticked towards the apparently inevitable return to that hotel room made him agree.

Anything to give him time to get his head around all this, and ensure he didn’t humiliate himself when the evening came to its planned conclusion.

“Come on!” she said. “Don’t you fancy some dancing?”

She grabbed his hand to drag him away from their table—it was clear to him there was little alternative other than go along with it. He let her pull him back through the pub, which was getting even more crowded now, getting towards the peak time of this Friday night.

It was clear enough to Jonah that going through with a one night stand with Emma would not mean he was exploiting her—she wanted this more than he did, it seemed. He still didn’t feel entirely comfortable with it.

Perhaps the worst thing was that he was genuinely enjoying her company. That brought with it a powerful mixture of feelings. On the good side, there was the warmth of unbridled lust, coupled with the exhilarating sense that this lust would be satisfied later that night. But deep down, it was countered by his huge sense of guilt—that he was out enjoying himself when others—namely, Nate—could not.

Then there was that innate monogamist within him that wondered whether he’d be hurt when the night ended and he was unable to take things any further with this lively girl.

“Hey, keep up!” she yelled as he fell behind, in danger of losing her as she headed out the exit.

He hurried to catch up, finding some relief in leaving the stuffy confines of the pub behind, the cool night air surrounding him.

“It’s just around the corner,” she said, waiting for him outside the front entrance

with her arm extended, seeking his.

And as he took her arm, Jonah made a decision. He resolved in his own mind that his enjoyment of his time with Emma would act as a kind of payment for the pain he would feel on leaving her behind, and for the work he was putting in to find the killer of his poor brother.

Based on that premise, he took a deep breath and willed all the guilt to leach out of his body.

After that, he felt better able to have a good time. He would keep his eyes open, and his ears to the proverbial ground, and prepare himself for the investigation ahead. But, he would also enjoy himself.

Wherever he was now, Jonah was sure that Nate would approve.



The nightclub was back on Covent Garden itself. The Roadhouse. It looked like a bit of a dive—a basement hole just around from the Transport museum.

There were bouncers outside, attempting to look intimidating to the line of twenty-somethings waiting to get inside. Not the kind of place Jonah would frequent, but then he probably hadn’t been in a night club for five years. Sleepy Oxford had boasted only the Park End club for years, which he had only ever managed to face back in his undergraduate days—and that had been after considerable amounts of booze.

But, this place was open, it was close, and the line outside suggested there might be enough people on the dance floor to conceal his total inability when it came to dancing.

“If we go back to your hotel this early,” she said as they found a place at the tail-end of the line, “They’ll think you’re paying for sex or something.”

“Aren’t I?” he said with a cheeky grin. “That hotel room wasn’t cheap!”

She poked him in the side, wrinkling up her face in scorn. “Listen, Mister, it’s not guaranteed, you know. I can still walk away.”

“And after seeing me dance, you probably will,” he said.

Although it was relatively early for a night club, the free entry before 11pm policy had thankfully packed out the dance floor, and after a stiff shot of vodka at the bar—downed with a whoop from Emma—they were soon jostling for space in the middle of the crowd.

Without much room for Saturday Night Fever antics, Jonah found they had to press against each other as they moved, which appeared no problem for Emma, who was all over him.

At first, he felt like a teenager again, trying to hide a burgeoning erection caused by this gorgeous girl. But this time, the first time she accidentally brushed against it on the dance floor, she gave him an enormous smile, eyes wide with surprise, positively glowing at the effect she was having on him.

And from then on, she did everything in her power to press herself against him, bumping into him, even ‘accidentally’ sweeping a hand between them, to run briefly over his hardness as she danced.

Whether or not the vodka was helping, Jonah found himself relaxing into the swing of things, enjoying the thrill of contact with the pretty blonde, from a clutch of her hand as she twirled, to a firm hold on her small waist or hips as she sashayed, and even the feel of her tight little behind as they danced close together.

The smell of her sweet coconut-tinged perfume was all pervasive, blending a little with the dark perspiration scent of those dancing around them, and the ever present sharpness of the alcohol, into a heady sensual cocktail.

She would kiss him as they danced, stretching up to smooch his lips, flashing that impish grin that seemed to be reminding him that they were due for something much hotter later that night.

When a slow number came up, Emma wedged herself in really close, holding him firmly around the waist and touching her velvet-soft cheek to his.

“Can’t take much more of this,” she said into his ear, and despite the crowd on the dance floor, the volume of the music gave their conversation some privacy.

“You’re tired?” he asked her, with a note of mild surprise in his voice.

“Horny!” she said in reply, and pulled him even closer, so his stiff cock pressed against her stomach.

As his boldness grew, Jonah was able to graze his fingers against the black fishnets stretched across her lower thighs, reaching up a little way to find the tops of her stockings under the hem of her dress, and then to luxuriate in the supple curve of her pert buttocks and the heat of her flesh.

Emma flashed him a little smirk, and pushed her dress back down, pulling his hands away.

With a quick glance to check no one could see, she looked into his eyes again, one eyebrow raised cryptically, and clutched one of his hands in hers. She brought it between them, down between her thighs and, his heartbeat pounding,

up under her dress.

He felt the raw heat of her sex even before his fingers were pressed against the hot, moist lace covering her there.

For a moment or two, she pressed his hand to her pussy, gazing into his eyes with a devilish grin.

Then she leaned in, and said: “You see how wet you make me?”

He smiled in return, and said: “I can do better.”

The music came to an end, changing to a boppy track that completely changed the mood. The dance floor became a little emptier as clubbers departed for more drink or a break from the heat of dancing, and Emma took a step back to break their intimate contact.

“Let’s go,” she almost growled.

Two

It was a short walk, no need for a cab. Emma virtually dragged him all the way, through Covent Garden and Theatreland to the even more packed Leicester Square, full of neon light and that brash, tacky energy of a permanent fairground.

As he followed her, Jonah felt as though he were locked in some strange ride himself—like a roller coaster, it was an accelerated attempt to experience physical sensations outside of ordinary existence.

In his case, it was fooling around with a sexy blonde who would ordinarily be out of the league of a quiet academic like him.

He was frightened—as much by the suddenness of their meeting and their transition to sex as the dark possibilities that his hunt for a killer offered. He was confident she couldn’t be a killer, but his fear stemmed more from the possibility that one of these nights, if he kept up his resolve, he could well meet with a woman who was.

However, for now, Jonah tried to calm himself by reasoning that the chances were astronomically small that he would stumble upon the killer so soon. It might be a one-in-a-million shot that he’d wind up selecting the right woman for this first date. No, there was going to be a certain amount of evolution for his methodology in this investigation. He had to narrow down the field, work to determine what kind of woman his brother would date, not to mention the other victims of this killer.

With few initial details about the kind of dates Nate had preferred, Jonah had only been able to begin by setting up a profile that might prove similar to Nate’s, and might attract the killer to date him, too.

“Robert!”

He didn’t react to the sound of his name at first, then as she repeated her call, he suddenly remembered. She thought he was Robert, an anonymous but well-off

stockbroker.

“Hey, come on!” she yelled, grabbing his hand again as they came by the Leicester Square branch of McDonalds, that Mecca of fast, throwaway culture.

Who knew what she did in her ordinary life? The advice on the website forum had been to avoid revealing too many personal details, if any at all. She might have been a secretary, or a shopgirl, or a public relations executive. Jonah didn’t know. She might have been a childcare specialist or an entrepreneur. Or a rich heiress. Who knew?

And here was the hotel again. The sight of it across the street from McDonald’s brought back the memory of the anxiety he’d experienced as he had checked in earlier that afternoon. Checking in under his real name, since hotels needed credit cards to book in their guests these days. Whatever happened to the days of Mr and “Mrs” John Smith and the care-free anonymous weekend in a guest house? What if somebody rang up to their room, asking for Mr Jonah Fielding?

Emma yanked him across the street towards the Thistle, but Jonah was finding the warm cushion of wine and vodka wearing off.

Shivering a little, he avoided looking at any of the desk staff on the way in, fearing their accusatory glares.

None came, and as the elevator doors closed, he afforded himself a quick glance back into the lobby, and no one seemed to have even noticed the young couple coming in from their night out.



Alone in the elevator, Emma grabbed him and pressed her lips to his again, forcing her body against his, letting out a little squeal of joy as she felt his hard cock even through his clothes.

There was Champagne waiting for them in the room when they got there, as he’d ordered earlier that day. Unnecessary, but an attempt at what his Robert persona might be expected to do. They clinked glasses and Jonah drained his glass, needing the support of the sharp alcohol.

Then he was kissing her, feeling her body against his, dropping the Champagne glass on the table by the TV.

His fingers slipped the straps of her dress over her shoulders, and the garment dropped to the carpet floor. He moaned lustfully at his view down her trim body, clad now only in her black lacy lingerie and those thigh-high fishnet stockings.

She smiled, a little bashful, despite her usual confidence.

She reached behind herself to spring open her push-up bra, which quickly fell to her feet to reveal perky, round breasts with hard little pink nipples, so cute, begging for his mouth.

They kissed again, and his hands found her soft breasts, caressing her milky flesh and grazing her nipples with his fingers and thumbs to tease the first moans from his one night stand.

He stooped, and took one nipple into his mouth, and then the other, teasing them with his lips and gently sucking each in turn to draw further groans from his sexy blonde.

“Oh Robert...”

He sank gradually into a kneel, kissing his way down her flat stomach and around her navel, down where the scent of her arousal grew stronger.

She placed her hands on his shoulders as he sank further, leaning in to touch his nose and lips to her abdomen, breathing in her strengthening fragrance while nudging downwards toward her mound.

“My, you are keen...” she murmured, but did not stop him.

For a moment, he nuzzled into her sex, loving the heat that was throbbing through its thin covering of black lace, hungry for the cocktail of her coconut-accent perfume and the darker spice from her pussy. He’d never been with a girl this beautiful before, and now that he was, it felt as though he’d stolen her. He had faked an identity, Robert, in order to win her. It only drove him on to experience her before the ruse was rumbled.

With eager fingers, he slipped her panties down over her hips and down her thighs, unveiling the stunning sight of her sex. Then he was kissing

her there, all around her most private place, her inner thighs, her mound, the little sprinkling of gold dust above her pussy. Overcome with a deep hunger as he inhaled the musky scent of her arousal.

Still standing, she parted her legs slightly to allow him access, and he took his first real taste of her tangy wetness.

“Oh God,” she breathed, and he felt her fishnet-clad legs weaken a little, her hands pressing down on him, her pussy crushing into his lips. “What are you doing?”

She quickly realized he was holding her weight, however, and relaxed a little, freeing him up to explore her soft, smoldering folds, drawing his tongue from the bottom of her slit upwards towards her hidden bud, rewarded by a long blissful moan.

Then she was urging him up, off his knees, stepping away to sit back on the side of the bed, looking at him as though he had just discovered the key to eternal youth or a cure for cancer.

He knelt between her thighs, lusting after her spice like a man possessed. He had almost forgotten how he adored the taste of a woman, it drove him wild. His PhD thesis had taken him away from normal society and the relationships for too long.

This time, however, he reached behind his head, grabbing a half-full glass of Champagne, which he then poured over Emma’s mound, making her squeal and giggle as the sparkling wine bubbled over her sensitive regions.

“You are a bad man, Robert!”

“Terrible.”

“Was the Champagne that bad?”

“Nope—but it’s better like this.”

She was his very own fine Champagne cocktail, the sharp, gently bitter fizz blending with the tangy, sweet syrup of her juices.

“Oh, I love it...” she sighed, as he gently brushed his tongue over her clit.

As he tended to her, his hands gliding up to her breasts, she gyrated her hips, dancing to the rhythm of his tongue on her sensitive folds, whimpering as he licked her, her chest heaving as she gasped for oxygen, the vibrant energy sweeping through her body.

He kept going, losing all track of time as he drew pleasure from hers, noticing how she dug her hands into the bed, fingers splayed out as though she feared being sucked into the mattress in some kind of paranormal event.

Sensing she was ready for it, he took her clit inside his hot mouth, focussing his tongue on that little magic button as he swept one hand down to assist. Sliding his middle finger inside her tight slit, her slick juices coated it as he gently coaxed her g-spot inside.

Soon, she was moaning constantly, her voice rising in pitch as the feelings intensified inside her. She lifted her hips a little off the bed, and, her body writhing under him, her juices flowing for him to lap up, she came with a shrill cry.

It was a while before she finally released him, allowing him to lie up on the bed next to her while she recovered.

Then she said: “You’re really not a City boy, are you?”

The words burned into him, made him feel helpless. He wasn’t much of a liar, never had been. That was the problem with his whole plan.

He was going to have to toughen up, to learn to lie, to become a much better actor. For now, though, there was probably no point in keeping up the pretense.

He would probably have to leave, of course, which was a shame. But he’d made a start in this, at least. Knew where he had to improve. Started the ball rolling.

“It’s okay, you know,” she smiled, turning to lie on her side. She stroked his cheek, said: “Everybody on this thing is trying to hide something about themselves.”

“Everybody?”

“Most. I mean, most of the men are married,” she rolled over onto her front now, one leg slipping over his. Then she was slowly unbuttoning his shirt, saying,

“I’ve never heard of anyone pretending to work in the City.”

“Some girls only go for City-types,” he said. A simple line, and not untrue.

“I can see that,” she said, running a couple of fingers inside his now-open shirt to caress his chest. “So you put it on your profile, to get that kind of girl?”

“I suppose.”

“Am I that kind of girl?”

Loving her touch, though still wondering if she was truly intending to stay that night, he said: “I don’t know. Are you?”

Her eyes flicked up for a moment, as though she were thinking. “Uh... well, sometimes. Sometimes, I come out on these dates and pretend like I’m one of those girls. Sometimes I don’t.”

She was fiddling with his belt now, it was a little tightly fastened. He asked:

“Did you tonight?”

“I think I was going to,” she said, “but I think I reconsidered.”

Belt unfastened, she pulled open his fly and sought out the hardness lying inside his boxer shorts. Then, as her fingers identified and traced out the swollen form of his hard cock, he asked her: “What gave me away?”

Always good to get a little feedback. So helpful for next time.

“To start with,” she said, gripping his erection now, trying to slip it through the fly in his underwear, “You let me lead us to the bar and the nightclub, and didn’t even flinch when I took you to the cheapest places around.”

He frowned and gave a little nod of acceptance.

“And then,” she went on, “you let me buy us drinks—the house red, no less. No showing off with the wine.”

“Okay,” he said.

“And you were too honest about it being your first time.”

“Ah,” he said. “But what if it’s all been an act? Making you think it was my first time. That I’m not a City trader.”

She grinned as she succeeded in exposing his long, stiff shaft to the cool air, and moaned as its full size became apparent. “Hello,” she said, feasting her eyes on it.

Then she looked up at him, and said: “If you truly were a City boy, there’s no way I would have come yet, and no way I’d ever come as hard as you just made me.”

He nodded again, quietly proud of himself.

She smiled, a heart-melting smile that seemed full of affection. “You would never have done that to me full stop,” she said quietly.

“No?”

“No,” she said, starting to coax his shaft, gently running her fingers up and down its length. “I’d have spent the first ten minutes fending you off from my asshole, and then you probably would have bent me over the table over there, and taken me from behind.”

“Oh,” he said, and found that the casual nature of her tone disturbed him a little.

“I’m not saying you can’t do that now,” she said, her fingers tightening around his cock, “But you didn’t, so you aren’t. A City boy, I mean.”

He nodded again, and wondered if she wanted to know what he was, his façade having crumbled. Would she want to stay with him if she knew he was just a lousy academic with nothing much in the bank but the last few remnants of a PhD grant?

“Maybe I’ll find out one day,” she said. “Doesn’t matter for now.”

Then he felt her hot mouth on the tip of his cock, kissing him there, flicking her tongue over his sensitive end, her silky golden locks spilling over his chest and then his thighs as her soft lips stretched around his swollen manhood.

He felt her hard little nipples brushing his skin as she leaned over him, swiveling around to get in a good position.

The sensations rippling through his body as his cock was enveloped by the heat of her mouth were exquisite, and as her head started to bob up and down, he saw her pert little behind next to him, and pulled her over towards him.

Lifting one stocking-clad knee over his chest, he was offered a superlative view of her pussy, and craned his neck to reach her, to kiss her, to taste her sweet nectar once again.

She was taken a little by surprise as his hands held her shapely hips, urging her downwards, but seeing that he wanted her, she relaxed, sinking down on his mouth, pushing her soaking pussy onto his eager lips.

His chin pressing to her clit, he ran the tip of his tongue up and down her slippery folds, then sank as deeply into her as he could muster, feeling her brace against him as he buried his face into her, fucking her with his tongue.

The exertions of his own mouth kept him from surrendering to hers, though after a little while, Emma appeared to be slowing her efforts, perhaps as she was building up to yet another orgasm.

Sitting up now, leaning back to envelop his whole face between her thighs, she was yelling as she shuddered on top of him. He did not complain as she seemed to forget herself for a few moments, merely lapped up her copious juices as a

willing servant.

“Goodness,” she said, realizing the position she’d put him in before quickly dismounting. “You really have to stop doing that if you want other girls to think you work in the City.”

“Other girls?”

“You know, if you want to try this again.”

“Right. Well, maybe I’ve got a lot to learn.”

She grinned, “I can teach you. I mean, if you want.”

“You can?”

The little blonde devil hopped up, and took a couple of steps over to the table by the TV.

“Lesson One,” she said, stooping and presenting her rear like a model in an adult magazine, “Fuck me from behind.”

His pants cast aside, he accepted her coaching and lined himself up, hands planted on her beautifully round buttocks, the tip of his cock poised at her searing lips, seeking an angle for entry. Then he pushed forward, and he was inside her, that exquisite burning tightness engulfing his rigid shaft.

He moved slowly at first, holding her firmly by the hips, finding her pushing back on him as he thrust forward, her soprano sighs reflecting his own deeper moans as his cock pulsed within her.

Reaching forward, he found her soft breasts and those hard, sensitive little pink nipples, like keys on a musical instrument he could play to produce the sweet music of her blissful cries.

“Oh, that’s good,” she moaned, “but harder now, much harder.”

He drove into her, giving up on her breasts to devote himself to the main event.

He found himself trying to imagine himself a cold-hearted serial one-night-stander, practicing his “Robert” persona again, hoping it would make him better

the next time.

“Fuck me,” she ordered, a note of desperation in her voice, “fuck me, fuck me, fuck me...”

And he was losing herself as he fucked her, even finding it a thrill to drive into her in a way he probably wouldn’t ordinarily.

“Don’t stop, don’t stop, Oh God, don’t stop...”

Then she was trembling again, he could feel her pussy quivering around his cock, and he was losing all control of himself now, pumping into her and releasing his oil deep inside her.

Collapsing on the bed afterwards, he wondered if a few more lessons with Emma might prepare him for the investigation ahead.

Though whether he could ever be fully prepared to meet the murderer of his brother, was still the big question—a question he both feared and yet hoped to answer some day soon.

Nate would have justice.

Three

“Housekeeping!”

The next morning, Jonah awoke to the sound of the hotel maid rapping on the door, ready to clean the room.

Shaking off the last remnants of sleep, he called out to prevent anyone from coming in, and turned over to find that Emma had gone.

The realization that she’d left gave him a little stabbing jolt to his heart. It hurt a little, that she could flee like that without even saying farewell. He had to stop, and remind himself that the main concept of the dating website they had been using was to engineer one night stands.

There should be no questions, no expectations, no strings.

Lying there on the bed, his cock rose to half mast, still tingling a little at the memory of the previous night’s activities. It hardly seemed real. Maybe he’d imagined it all. But he could still detect her sweet scent in

the air, along with the lingering traces of their sex. It had definitely happened.

Emma had been quite something, that was for sure—he'd definitely lucked out on his first attempt at a one night stand, though now it was over, it was a shame he wouldn't get to see her again.

Heaving a sigh, he accepted why she'd slipped out while he'd been asleep. It would be easier to avoid the awkward goodbyes.

Still.

A quick glance at his watch explained the intrusion from the maid—it was already noon. It was no wonder he'd slept late, considering the lateness of the hour when he and the pretty little blonde had collapsed into a heavy slumber.

But, it was time to get going.

He peeled back the sheets and hoisted himself to his feet.

There was to be a viewing at Nate's apartment at five, so he had plenty of time to get showered and cleaned up before the estate agent brought in the potential buyers. It might be good to get back and do a little more packing first, though.

Nate's apartment. His stomach sank at the reminder that his brother was gone.

He seemed to get this every day, sometimes quite a few times a day, but never so powerful as when he first woke up.

He grabbed the remote, flipping on the first 24-hour news channel he could find on the big TV, hoping to drown out the encroaching gloom.

Then he scanned the room for his clothes, and as he did so he noticed a scrap of paper in the middle of the writing desk, which had not been there before.

His heart leaped, and surely enough it was from Emma.

“Dear Jonah,” the note said, and he could hear her rapid-fire voice within her closely-scrawled words: “I’m sorry I had to leave—you were sleeping, and unfortunately I have a wedding to attend today, otherwise I would have woken you up for another go. Last night was incredible—I think I came more in one night than I have for a year. You’re a really special guy, and I would love nothing more than another night with you some day. Take care, love Emma xx”

Jonah smiled as he read it, and his heart warmed enough to melt much of the pain of losing her. There was hope in that letter, hope that he could see her again.

Certainly enough to be going on with.

He really did want to see Emma again—he had never felt anything like the roller coaster ride of being with her. Attractive, smart, funny—it was a real shame she was just a one night stand to him, and he to her. He was going to have to get used to this—tough for a natural monogamist.

“...body was found at the Hilton Hotel on London’s Park Lane this morning. We don’t have many details at this point, but the Hotel confirmed...”

The voice of the news presenter cut through his heart like a dagger.

“...Police have not yet released a name, but sources suggest the victim was a

member of the investment banking community...”

Jonah felt his insides swamped by an ugly heat. It had happened again.

He sat there on the bed, suddenly feeling very small and pathetic. Had he really thought he might locate and identify the killer by pursuing a ridiculous game of chance through his hunch that Nate had met his end via an internet dating website?

God. Victim number four, slain in another hotel. That could have been him.

“...some have already linked it to the death of Lord Moss and the two other men found in hotel rooms in the past 12 months, but police are still

refusing to suggest the murders are all the work of one killer...”

Jonah felt the sharp acid of rage building inside his stomach at the reminder of how useless the police investigation had been up to this point. How could they ignore the obvious fact that all four victims had been found in hotel rooms? They were obviously linked.

There was a serial killer hunting men.

Now there had been a fourth victim, he felt the bitter I-told-you-so satisfaction of knowing he’d been right about this all along. The police hadn’t taken kindly to his assertion that Nate had been despatched by a sadistic serial killer, who might be killing at random. They wanted to believe he’d had enemies, or that he’d done something to provoke a woman into killing him.

The certainty that he’d been on the right track also made him feel he’d been somewhat foolish in falling asleep with Emma, despite being fairly certain she could not have been the killer. A basic mistake, and one that had made him so very vulnerable.

She could have stabbed him while he slept. She’d certainly been able to gather her things together, write him a note and then slip out of the hotel room without waking him. Next time, if there was a next time, there was no way he could afford to fall asleep with someone from the website.

As he finished dressing himself, Jonah wondered if he would have the courage to continue the quest to find his brother’s murderer.

Then a picture of his brother flicked up on the television screen for a moment, on the report about the latest murder victim. The face was almost as familiar to him as his own reflection in the mirror.

Pain squeezed his heart like a vice.

There was no question he would continue his search for the killer.



Riding in a Tube train crowded with commuters, Jonah realized that Emma had used his real name on her note, rather than the one he'd been using for his website profile.

How had she figured it out?

Perhaps he'd said something at some point, the Champagne loosening his tongue as much as his inhibitions. Perhaps he'd just left his wallet lying around.

He'd have to be so much more careful next time.



The street outside the hotel on Park Lane was filled with police vehicles, a crime scene truck, even a forlorn ambulance that looked rather pointless given the scenario inside the building. Jonah could see the TV cameras stationed across from the hotel entrance. It all seemed to confirm the initial reports as to what had happened in that place. It made Jonah feel his heart sink to know someone else had suffered the same fate as his brother.

He ventured in through the revolving door into the lobby, mentally preparing for the role of an innocent hotel guest, in case anyone asked him.

There didn't seem to be any yellow police tape stopping ordinary Joes from going into the hotel. In fact, inside, everything seemed like business as usual for the Hilton, other than the view out of the windows of police cars and vans. The police must have sealed off the relevant floor on which the crime had taken place. There was precious little need to disrupt the rest of the hotel.

There were a couple of police officers milling around the relatively empty lobby.

Jonah avoided them—they'd have instructions to move on anyone curious about what was being splashed all over the world's news media right now.

“Hi... Uh...”

“Do you have a reservation, sir?”

The desk jockey was prim and proper, and apparently on alert for any who might think otherwise. Jonah suddenly felt out of his depth. What was he doing there?

Trying to sneak his way in? Was he really going to get additional details the police would not make public?

“I... Uh... Was wondering what floor they’ve got sealed off. I normally like a room on the 12 th or 13 th...”

Did he really think he’d be able to get up there, ask a few quiet questions to whoever he found up on the floor of the crime scene?

“We can’t give out that kind of information, sir,” the desk clerk said in that irritating clipped manner, snooty for no reason.

“Are you a member of the press, sir?” One of the other clerks turned to him, having semi-heard his question or his colleague’s reply.

“Uh... well...” Jonah said, more by way of a defense than any real intent to deceive. He was already thinking better of his strategy, thinking he should have quietly found some lowly bellhop or maid to tell him what was generally known around the hotel about the crime scene found within.

But the other clerk said now: “The press conference is in the Grimmond Room

—you might just about catch the beginning if you hurry.”

“Thanks,” he said, ignoring the look the original reception clerk was giving him regarding his puny attempt to garner information.

Jonah nodded his understanding of the directions the guy was giving him—and now he could hardly ignore them. A press conference—now, that peaked his interest.

There were signs to the Grimmond Room, which appeared to be among the parts of the hotel normally used for corporate events and conferences. Two women sat outside the room itself, one in uniform, the other in a suit. They ushered him inside without even stopping to ask for credentials, perhaps because the press conference was already underway.

Jonah took a deep breath and plunged through the double doors, fearful he'd find himself walking in to become the center of attention of all those gathered inside, humiliated as some kind of busy body who had no reason to be at an official press conference.

Or perhaps he'd be arrested, his continuing need for getting involved in the ongoing case taken as some kind of suspicion of guilt.

Through the door, however, he was hit by a barrage of noise, and then he found himself pitched into a melee of people and equipment, almost becoming lost in the maelstrom.

The room was not huge, perhaps the size of a small lecture theater at a university, with rows of seats built into a sloping floor down to a small stage marked by a backdrop emblazoned with the familiar colors and logos of the Metropolitan Police.

There appeared to be hundreds of people crammed into that room, along with dozens of television cameras and all manner of lighting technology set up in every available space. Jonah found himself at the back of the room, where it was standing room only, and those who stood had to be careful not to trip over the array of electrical cables on the floor.

Chaos.

Most of the assembled hoard appeared to be journalists, bearing notepads, microphones or tape recorders, all focused firmly on the police officers lined up on the stage at the front of the room. A few more stood around the cramped area at the back, where Jonah found himself, in front of a bank of television cameras looming up to film the proceedings above the heads in front.

A low murmur of hushed conversation among the crowd made it difficult to hear what was being said. Jonah glanced at the guys manning the TV cameras, who appeared to care nothing about the noise thanks to their

chunky headsets linked up to the forest of microphones up there on stage in front of the detectives.

Jonah recognized the lead detective on the case, a man he'd tried to contact personally a number of times to share his thoughts, most recently his strong suspicion that his brother had met his killer through that online dating website.

"...we're not saying the killer is definitely one of these three women. But they all visited the hotel that night and we cannot as yet confirm their identities..."

He felt a flicker of irritation, even anger, over the man's obstinate ignoring of his suggestion about the dating website back when he'd been questioned. It was the obvious way in which Nate had met his killer, and yet the police were dismissing it out of hand because the website left no traces on Nate's computer.

"...We'd like them to get in touch, or anyone who recognizes them, so we can rule them out from our inquiry..."

Behind the detectives, a screen showed grainy, poor-quality black-and-white CCTV images of three women the police had already picked out as possible suspects. Jonah peered at them. At least one of them appeared to be wearing a wig. One of them had sunglasses. None of them were readily identifiable.

"...we are under the impression that it is a woman we are looking for, yes," the

detective was saying in response to a question from a journalist up near the front.

Jonah jostled his way forward, and into the central aisle of the room, where more journalists were seated on the steps. He could see space a little way down, closer to the front, which he thought might offer easier hearing for what was going on.

Treading carefully to avoid stepping on reporters, Jonah made his way down to the single square foot of available space in the room.

“...there are a few similarities between the cases, but far too many differences to treat these as anything other than separate crimes. There’s just no evidence linking these murders.”

“But they did all take place in London hotels?”

“That would appear to be the case, but there’s no evidence it’s anything other than a purely circumstantial factor at this stage.”

As Jonah reached the spot, he looked up at the detectives all lit up by stage lighting to find the gaze of the Chief Superintendent fixed on his face.

“Your question?” the senior detective asked, and Jonah flushed as he felt the eyes of the world’s media focus on him as well.

The police chief had mistaken his being on his feet with wanting to ask the next question.

Jonah took a quick breath and decided he had no option but to ask his question.

He said: “This latest victim, did he meet his killer through an online dating website?”

He saw a puzzled look pass briefly over the face of the police chief—perhaps the man was surprised that the question would relate to such a specific detail of the victim’s habits, not the usual question being asked by the media as to whether all these deaths were at the hands of a single killer.

Jonah felt certain it was a single serial killer behind all these murders. There wasn’t any point in asking the police that.

The detective’s surprised expression remained in place only a moment before he

regained his composure, his media training kicking in.

“Our detectives are following up every possible lead and every potential detail,”

he said. His tone dismissed Jonah's question as though it was an insignificant detail. It made Jonah's blood boil.

The police chief's eyes were moving on, to seek out other questions immediately his non-answer to Jonah had left his mouth. The throng of journalists around the room rumbled into a clamor as each one tried to claim the next question.

Jonah spoke loudly, above the murmur: "It's quite obvious that these murders are all linked, so surely you should be looking into how these four men came to meet the woman who murdered them?"

The reporters around him were silenced briefly, paying attention to this particular question.

The silver-haired police chief looked tired. He glared at Jonah with bloodshot eyes, waited a moment for silence to be restored. Then he said: "You want me to say these murders might be the work of a single, deranged killer, I can't do that.

"The best I can do is say there were similarities about the last two victims. They were both employed in the City. They both appear to have met a woman they did not know, for the purposes of having a single nocturnal encounter. Beyond that, there's nothing much we can say—including how these two young men went about organizing their dates."

Jonah insisted, "So you're considering the possibility of a dating website..."

But the other man shook his head. "Martin Sallow was a known user of prostitutes, so that is the line of inquiry we are following. There is no evidence he used a dating website to meet the woman he was with last night."

"There's no evidence that he didn't," Jonah insisted. "There's no evidence any of them didn't."

The journalists around him were getting interested in this exchange, their eyes lighting up to the possibility that Jonah knew something, more than the rest of them, about this case.

Jonah sat down. What made him nervous was not necessarily the journalists getting interested in him, but the detectives standing just off the stage talking amongst themselves and nodding toward him, as though he was in trouble for infiltrating this press conference. Did they recognize him? He thought he knew a couple of the faces from the days after Nate's death, when they'd interviewed him time after time. He'd never seen the pretty brunette before, though. He would have remembered her.

"Douglas Moss was a peer of the realm. He was a devoted husband and father."

The police chief was still glaring at Jonah even after he'd sat down. Was he in trouble? Could you get thrown in jail for hoodwinking police officers into thinking you were a member of the press?

The senior officer growled through gritted teeth: "He was a man of high standing and impeccable behavior. He did not meet women through the internet."

Jonah was about to come back at the guy, his chest burning with anger. But the police chief had moved on to other questions. He wasn't going to entertain any more theories from Jonah.

The establishment was circling the wagons, moving to protect itself. The second murder victim was a Member of the House of Lords, as well as an investment banker, and so the investigation would be careful not to cast any aspersions even if it did hold up the rest of the hunt for a killer who had sex with men before killing them.

Jonah was too far into the mass of journalists for the detectives to haul him out without making a complete spectacle of themselves in front of the world's press, but sitting through the rest of the press conference, he felt like a marked man, felt the eyes of those detectives fixed on him, wondered if they were plotting what kind of charge they might get him on once he was away from the safety of media observers.

Was he breaking any laws being there at the press conference? No one had really checked his credentials, he hadn't needed to deceive anybody to get there.

Jonah tried to keep calm, but he took advantage of the crowd at the end of the press conference, as journalists flocked forward in attempts to gain one-on-one time with the detectives on the case, while others flowed out to the exit in back,

to get out and file a story. It allowed him to slip out unmolested by irate detectives.

The press conference had provided precious little additional detail on the first three victims—Julian Foster, Lord Douglas Moss, and Jonah’s dear brother, Nate.

The police had a point when they said there was no great consistency in the victims—three of the four had strong links to the financial sector, but the first, Julian Foster, was a journalist, and not a financial one. Nate and Martin Sallow had been unmarried, while Julian Foster and Douglas Moss had both been married.

According to the police, Martin Sallow had been tied to a bed and stabbed.

Though it made him sick to even think of it, he knew Nate had had his throat cut.

Julian Foster had been strangled. Lord Moss... well, those details were not in the public domain.

The press seemed taken with the idea that a female serial killer was operating in London hotels. The police, though, were stubbornly clinging to the idea that these were separate crimes, with separate motives and separate suspects.

“Serial killers are rare in Britain as it is,” the lead detective had said. “Female serial killers are like unicorns.”

Jonah could name Myra Hindley and Rose West off the top of his head for starters, and there had been a child-killer nurse in the 1990s, he seemed to recall.

Women could be just as evil as men.



After the press conference, Jonah felt too freaked out to stay around the hotel. It had probably been a bad idea coming, he knew it was frustration at the slow progression of the case that had pushed him to be there. He hadn't thought out his strategy particularly well.

The other consideration for his quiet exit was the fact that the police detectives had recognized him when he'd asked that question about the dating website.

He'd seen them whispering to each other while looking at him, as though they were planning something to teach him not to sneak into their press conferences.

On leaving the hotel, it was head-down, hunched shoulders for Jonah.

Nevertheless, he wasn't entirely successful in doing so.

"Jonah!"

He turned to see a man not much older than himself with overly long ginger hair swept back, pale freckled skin and a somewhat intense face with piercing blue eyes bloodshot from overwork or insufficient sleep. His scruffy suit made Jonah relax a little, with the impression that this guy wasn't police.

"It is Jonah Fielding, right?" he said, with a hint of South London in his accent.

Jonah glanced at the hotel exit. Out on the curb a group of tourists were attempting to get an older member of their party into a taxi with a wheelchair, and it was slow going. He wouldn't be able to dash out there and just grab a cab himself to avoid this guy, who had to be a reporter.

"Right," he turned to the guy, groaned inwardly.

The ginger-haired guy smiled toothily at the confirmation that he was correct.

“Harold Keeley,” he said. “I write for the Guardian.”

Well, he wasn’t from the Daily Mail, which had to be a plus.

“What you were saying back there,” he asked. “You do think all these murders are linked, right?”

Jonah paused. “I can’t talk to you,” he said.

Keeley ran his hand through his hair. “You think they were all involved in online dating? Even Lord Moss?”

Well, if the police weren’t taking his theory seriously, perhaps the media would.

So far, he’d respected the advice of the police in not talking to the press about his suspicions, his reaction to other murders, anything. But the police weren’t doing much good.

“I don’t know,” he said, feeling dejected. “Maybe one of the murders is something else... not linked...”

“You know, I have a source saying the police are sifting through prostitutes for a suspect? Saying your brother and this latest one were both that way inclined...

and maybe that other guy, the journo.”

Jonah felt a jolt of shock tear through his chest. Jesus, was this going to come out in the press? People would think his brother used prostitutes, soon as it was in print. There was no way Nate was that kind of person.

“Nate did not pick up prostitutes,” he said, sounding a little more certain than he really could be.

“This online dating thing, this is your way of protecting your brother’s reputation...”

“I know for a fact that he dated women through an online dating site,” Jonah said, trying to be calm. “There just wasn’t any need for him to pay for sex.”

“What was the website he used? And what kind of women did he go for?”

Well, that was the question, wasn't it?

Jonah shrugged. “I'm sorry, I really don't know anything more.”

Keeley thrust a card into his hand. “Give me a shout some time,” he called as Jonah headed for the revolving door out of the building. “If you think of anything else!”



Before waking so late, and gatecrashing a press conference, he had originally been planning to spend that particular day at the British Library, resuming work on his thesis. Yet once again the day was all but spent already. He wasn't going to be able to get back to retrieve his research notes and then have any meaningful time left to continue his crawl through the necessary academic papers before he'd have to show another group of potential buyers around the apartment.

But there was enough time to check on that website again.

He felt a tinge of guilt as he once again chose not to dedicate himself to his PhD.

It was difficult to concentrate on his chosen field—the impact of climate change on the migratory habits of European birds—when he had more pressing matters to tend to, namely justice for his dead brother.

Trying not to dwell on it, Jonah hopped on a number 73 bus for the journey to Marble Arch, and then along Oxford Street to Tottenham Court Road. His usual haunt for accessing the website, a large internet cafe that offered suitable anonymity, was located there just above a Burger King restaurant that now handily provided a little low-grade sustenance to placate his grumbling belly.

On the street outside, it was hard to avoid the headlines splashed all over the newspaper boards promoting the Evening Standard newspaper. “Scotland Yard: Murders linked”.

Jonah picked up a copy, and could see that the free tabloid was having a field day with the quotes he himself had drawn from the police chief, suggesting that at least the two most recent hotel murders could be linked. True to tabloid form, they were already speculating that a “sexy female killer” was prowling London with a taste for the blood of City bankers.

It pained him more than a little to think that Nate’s terrifying and painful death was now merely little more than a sales aid for the newspapers. He appreciated it was their job, however. And of course like many people around him, he had to get a copy for himself.

Even just scanning through paper on the way up the stairs to the internet cafe brought back the anger.

The way the latest victim was described, not yet confirmed by the police though with sketchy details supplied by a ‘source close to the investigation’, was clearly along the same lines as Nate. The other two victims might not quite fit the profile, but serial killers didn’t have to kill from one particular societal group, did they?

The very nature of the serial killer was to kill at random.

According to the piece, Martin Sallow had been found with marks around his wrists, as though he’d been shackled at some point during the night. The newspaper was keen to highlight that particular detail—attempting to portray the whole thing like some kind of Basic Instinct-style thriller.

Jonah’s exhaustion from the previous night’s pursuits with Emma seemed to drain away as he read on, replaced by his simmering rage. If that Guardian journalist had been right, and behind the scenes the police were beginning to attach themselves to the idea that a rogue prostitute was behind these killings, even only some of them, then Nate’s reputation was about to be dragged through the mud.

He’d come into this place quite a few times in the past few months. As British internet cafes went, it was huge. Not so much a “cafe”, with its row upon row of computers, like some kind of battery farm for web surfers. But it did supposedly serve food and beverages. It wasn’t so unpleasant. This time, it wasn’t very full, giving Jonah plenty of space and relatively good privacy to access the site. He might have the

resources to get his own laptop once his brother's estate was sorted out, but he wasn't sure how he felt about the windfall that would represent.

Sitting down in an empty row, the people nearest him appeared to be youngish immigrants and students, but they seemed fairly preoccupied with talking amongst themselves.

They reminded Jonah that he had no real friends in London.

His short time with Emma had been the first time for a while that he'd been able to let things go and even enjoy himself. Perhaps it had been selfish of him, but all this isolation had made him feel the need for human interaction he hadn't ever felt in the cosy halls of his Oxford college, shut in with his books and papers. Nate had often inquired about Jonah's social life while all he really

wanted to do was study and achieve. Now, he was beginning to see his brother's point.

It was this sprawling metropolis: it brought out the loneliness in you.

There had been the occasional offers of drinks with some of Nate's friends over the past couple of weeks, of course, but the few evenings he had braved such offers, hanging out with Nate's circle had ended up being quite upsetting. He was constantly viewed by the others with expressions of pity and regret. He couldn't relax, felt that even a smile seemed somehow inappropriate.

With Emma, he had been able to pretend to be someone else for a few hours—

even though his pretending had been more than a little incompetent.

Perhaps his experiment to draw out Nate's killer was really just a manifestation of his genuine need to reach out to people.

He checked his email briefly, and there was nothing much apart from a message from Nate's email provider stating what Jonah had expected, that the company could not provide Nate's email password because of its privacy rules. It seemed ridiculous, Nate being dead, but Jonah could understand it. Perhaps the police had had better luck tapping into his brother's email, but Jonah himself had no official status.

Then, he was logging into the No Strings website, or at least trying to. Since he hadn't returned to the apartment yet that day, he didn't have his notebook in which the password for his account was scrawled. He clicked on the "forgot password" link under the log-in boxes on the website. It offered him a couple of straightforward security questions, and forced him to then change his password into something more memorable. Then he was in.

He was surprised to find a few flirty messages waiting for him in his inbox once he was logged in.

From what he had read about online dating, usually the male users vastly outnumbered the female, and therefore a male user would seldom attract much interest without having first sent out a raft of messages seeking it. Jonah's profile on this website, however, under the name "Robert", seemed to be picking up some interest. It appeared that modeling his profile on his brother was doing the trick—young women liked to date affluent City boys, it seemed.

Looking at the photographs and a few of the details of those who had messaged him, Jonah had to remind himself that this wasn't about his own personal choice.

He had very little to go on for the moment in terms of who the killer might be, but he had to at least start looking among the types of girls Nate would go for on a website like this.

So, while 26-year-old Kelly might have been more of Jonah's type, and was certainly attractive according to her picture, he thought she might be a little too bookish for Nate. Regretfully, she was not going on Jonah's list.

Maybe one day, when all of this was over, if he was still looking for more of a long-term relationship, he could start looking for the right kind of person through a website like this, albeit a more conventional one for normal dating, not the kind of one night stand that No Strings advocated. But not yet.

Among the possibilities now offered, two girls appeared much more of Nate's caliber. Both were good looking. The prospect of meeting women

like these explained why someone as socially confident as Nate might bother with such a thing as an online adult matchmaking service.

Sadie appeared to be a leggy brunette who also worked in the City, seeming from her picture, profile and message to be quite sophisticated and Jonah suspected probably quite posh. She made Jonah wonder if her working in the City might mean she would see through his “Robert” disguise. But then, the guidance on the website forum did state that he ought to avoid talking about his real life, so that could be an easy defense.

He couldn’t afford to discount women who worked in Nate’s own sphere if he was going to track the killer, though.

Becky was a redhead who said she was a nurse. Nate had always had a thing for nurses—so this freckly 23-year-old was definitely worth checking out. He thought she’d hardly invent such a profession for her profile, despite the advice to keep real details like that a secret.

Perhaps being a nurse meant she was unlikely to be a killer. Perhaps not. You couldn’t tell these days, the number of medical professionals who had turned psycho in recent years. Jonah thought perhaps having medical knowledge would give a killer some advantage in actually carrying out the deed.

So, he replied to those two messages, to let them know he was available any evening they cared to name. The others he would leave for a day or so, before deciding whether it was a good idea to rule them out of his investigation.

He spent a while tinkering with his profile, attempting to find if there was any way to improve his introductory blurb to make himself seem more like Nate, thereby bettering his chances of attracting the attentions of the killer.

Just as he was finishing up, ready to log-out and slip out to find some supper somewhere, he saw another message drop into his in-box. It was from Becky, asking if it was too cheeky of her to ask if he was free that very evening.

Jonah sighed, and a few heads around him turned to see what his sudden noise was about. He was tired, and it was tempting to decline her request,

or suggest another evening. He figured she wouldn't mind—and if she did mind, who cared? He'd find someone else.

However, he was quite keen to make progress, and got the feeling that if he turned down a date now, it might be a while until another one came along. Plus, Becky was quite tempting, if her picture was accurate.

He could sleep on Sunday, he decided, and replied to her that he was available that evening.

This time, he was pleased to see a sudden reply. She suggested they meet at Tufnell Park Underground Station, which Jonah had to look up—it was in North London, up the Northern Line.

She said she had an aqua-aerobics class after work, but could then meet him afterwards, perhaps at 8pm.

Jonah approved. It would give him just enough time to get home and change into fresh clothes.

Then, just as he was logging off the website, he realized something: if he could find out Nate's username, he might be able to work out his brother's security questions and gain access to his account.

That could be a major step forward in his investigation.

But he didn't have time to think about it much, if he was going to get home and prepared for the next date.

Four

Nate's apartment was in a smart tower overlooking the water on West India Quay, just across the bouncy steel walkway from the cluster of commercial and financial office buildings that was London's Canary Wharf area.

It was an amazing place, with a Marriott hotel taking the lower floors of the 33-floor building. Nate's apartment was pretty amazing too, even though it was apparently one of the smaller ones in the building. It was extravagantly spacious, with extraordinary views of the revitalized London Docklands.

It had always impressed Jonah to visit his brother, though these days when he arrived here, he felt mainly despair. Though Nate had always been quick to praise Jonah's own achievements in the academic world, there was no mistaking that his brother had been the achiever in life. It was part of the tremendous sense of injustice that pulsed inside of him now—Nate had been so full of life, only to be snuffed out like that.

As he arrived, he saw a police car parked outside the building. It was unmarked, but had a police warning light attached to the roof, on the driver's side, so it was clear what it was—not to mention the fact it was parked in an area usually reserved for pedestrians.

Jonah's heart hopped a little inside, from the feeling that someone must be here to see him. A police officer. Had they come to their senses about his theory?

There wasn't much else he could do for them at the moment—he'd been questioned to ludicrous lengths already, in the days following the discovery of Nate's body.

As he approached the building entrance, the driver's door of the police car opened, and a smart young brunette stepped out. It was the attractive detective he'd noticed at the press conference, no less. Her tidy but inexpensive suit was doing its best to play down her femininity, but she was quite something.

"Jonah Fielding?"

"Yes, that's me."

She was pretty, in a slightly unconventional way, with her long dark hair tied in a ponytail and little black-rimmed spectacles perched on her nose, shielding hazel eyes that were just a touch too large for her face.

Jonah thought she was a bit younger than him, though it was difficult to tell.

Young for a detective, at any rate. Perhaps she was a fast-track straight from university.

"DI Mulray," she said, flashing an ID in front of her. "I'm the new liaison officer for the investigation, sir. I was just wondering if now was a good

time...”

Jonah thought it slightly strange she didn’t have a partner with her. Detectives usually came in pairs, didn’t they? Blenin hadn’t, but then Blenin was an overbearing brute. It seemed like having a partner might be safer on a murder investigation for someone like DI Mulray.

“What happened to Blenin?” he said, not meaning to sound quite so obtuse.

“He’s been transferred.”

Jonah paused. Blenin had been tasked with keeping him in line, although the official version had been that he was a liaison officer, responsible for keeping the information flow going between the police and the next of kin. Had his stunt at the press conference led to the guy being kicked off the investigation?

“He got kicked out?” Jonah asked.

“Promoted, actually. He’s heading up a local narcotics task force in Haringey.”

Jonah nodded. The false-sounding positivity in her voice made him feel sorry for her. This was a crappy job for a detective, babysitting. And if he kept up his attempts to influence the investigation—as he was determined to do—she would no doubt find herself trapped in some kind of career dead-end like Blenin, busting local drug dealers in some scrubby part of the city.

He realized she was waiting for an answer. She wanted to talk to him.

God, had they sent the most attractive woman on the force to try to persuade him

to stop his meddling? Was that why she was here?

“Uh... look, I have to hop in the shower quickly—I’ve got a few people coming round to look at the apartment,” he said. “Can it wait?”

“It’ll only take a few minutes, sir,” she said.

A sigh. He wasn't going to shake her off the scent.

"Do you mind coming up?"

"Of course."

Jonah held the door for her, catching a waft of what he thought might be cinnamon as she thanked him before stepping inside the building.

In the close confines of the elevator, her cinnamon accent was a little more obvious, though still professionally subtle. It made Jonah suddenly concerned that his own pre-shower scent might be too apparent to the attractive police detective. Outwardly, though, she didn't appear to have noticed.

"I would have thought they'd have kept someone like you focused on this latest victim," he said as the elevator made its overly slow way towards the 22 nd floor.

She said, "I've only recently joined C.I.D. They keep us newbies away from all the important stuff."

He thought he detected a faint sigh, but her expression remained fairly impassive.

"So we're not important, us next-of-kin?" he joked. Look at him, making light of things. He was already getting taken in by the attractions of this delicious brunette.

She cracked a smile briefly, but then quickly reined it in, returning to her professional demeanor. "I meant to say 'urgent'," she corrected herself. "Of course it's important to keep communications open with you, sir."

He let it go, and as the elevator finally arrived on Nate's floor, he said: "I went to

your press conference this morning."

"Yes, you did." Her tone was neutral, but he still got the impression she was disapproving.

“I just wanted to talk to someone about the latest murder—the latest victim. I didn’t mean to get shunted into the actual press conference...”

She nodded. “It’s frustrating. Murder investigations take time, it doesn’t always seem that progress is being made.”

“Is it true, they’re linking this latest one to Nate’s murder?”

“They’re more likely to be linked than the other hotel killings.”

The doors opened, and DI Mulray stepped out into the small hallway, off which four apartments adjoined.

“The latest one—do you know if he was into the whole internet dating thing, like Nate?”

The detective seemed to be mulling over whether she should be talking about this with him. Then she said: “It seems likely he met a lot of women for one night stands. It’s just the internet part of that that’s hard to show.”

“Hmm,” standing in front of Nate’s door, Jonah paused, then tapped in the code on the electronic key pad to open the door. “Because the website is designed to be discreet, not to leave evidence on a user’s computer.”

“That would make it difficult to prove your theory, yes.”

Stepping inside Nate’s apartment, he saw a flicker in the detective’s eyes that betrayed the fact that she was impressed at the place. It was hard not to be, even if it wasn’t a penthouse. The open plan layout and smart, minimalist interior design made it seem a lot larger than it really was. As did the fact that half of Nate’s belongings were already in cardboard boxes.

“Take a seat if you like,” he said. “You don’t mind if I grab a very quick shower first? I’ve got people coming round very soon. We have to sell this place...”

“Sure, no problem,” she said, but rather than accepting the offer of a sofa, preferred to stand and admire the view through the floor-to-ceiling windows.

“Sorry about all the boxes.”

Jonah dashed through to the bedroom, which was little more than an area of the apartment penned off from the main living space by bookshelves, a tall plant and more boxes.

He wasn't really used to having guests at Nate's apartment.

Grabbing his towel from its apparent home on the bedroom floor, he ducked into the en suite bathroom and switched on the shower to allow it time to warm up while he stripped down.

“Do you work in the City like your brother did?” Jonah heard DI Mulray's raised voice over the flow of the water.

“No,” he said in a similarly raised voice, while stepping under the gloriously warm flow of the water. “No, I'm just a poor academic down from Oxford. I'm afraid I didn't mix in Nate's circles.”

“But you were close enough to know about his dating habits?”

He could tell she had wandered closer, so that she didn't have to raise her voice as much—she seemed to be standing by the island that bounded the kitchen area of the apartment. It made sense, if he didn't have too much time for questions.

The shower felt oh-so good after his long night of abandon.

“Help yourself to coffee, if you like,” he suggested, spluttering a little as he carelessly applied the shampoo, and it ran into his eyes and mouth. Then, answering her question, he said: “We were close. Told each other most things, things we didn't tell anyone else.”

“Did he date a lot of women?”

He could hear her opening cupboards to look for a mug.

“Other than through that website, the occasional girl from work. Maybe the odd

one he met on a night out—no one particularly long-term. He wasn't really ready for all that—still too focused on work.”

“He seemed to do pretty well for himself at work,” the detective said, and Jonah could hear her pressing buttons on the coffee machine. “Did he ever... pay for sex... as far as you know?”

“Never. And if he had, he would have told me,” Jonah insisted, though silently he recalled that Nate hadn’t said anything about seeing married women, which apparently was the common thing for single guys on that particular website. “He just didn’t need to pay for it. The kind of women he met through that website...”

She said: “Tell me about this website—he told you which one he used?”

Jonah stood there, enjoying the warmth of the water, his eyes closed as it splashed down over him to patter over the expensively tiled floor.

“We were talking about it just before he went out on his date that night.”

“And that’s why you’re so sure his killer met him through that website?”

He paused. “I know he didn’t get stood up—he sent me a text telling me she was... well, quite attractive.”

“He send you any more texts that night?”

“No, not after that. You know, when he was with her, he was pretty focused.”

“He’d told you about previous dates?”

“A few. He kept trying to persuade me to do it, too. Wanted me to meet more people, get out more. Worried about his boring nerd of a little brother.”

Murray smiled, nodded, and Jonah almost felt as though her reaction might be some kind of empathy with him. Then she said, “Tell me about the website.”

“It’s called ‘No Strings’. It’s not quite a Match.com, it’s more specializing in instant sex—one night stands. Lot of married people use it, apparently, so it’s designed to leave zero traces on your computer.”

“That right?”

“Nate said it was quite a popular site in City circles—if you want to, you could find someone on there and be sleeping with them within a few hours.”

“Charming,” said Mulray. It seemed a little amusing to him that he was standing here completely naked, so close to her now—just a thin wall between them.

“That’s the way the world is moving, Detective,” he said. “Instant gratification on tap.”

“How does the site work?” she asked.

“Basically, you create a profile for yourself, upload a photo and details of what you’re looking for and where you’re located.”

“Sounds fairly standard.”

“Then you can search for potential matches in the database, and if you’re interested in someone, you add them to your list. They might then contact you asking for a date, or might just add you to their list, in which case you can contact them,” Jonah explained as he rinsed off.

“And you contact them what, by email?”

“Through the website—they have a simplified email system so that you can send messages to other members.”

“I see. So when you sign up to this website, you don’t need to use your own personal email account?”

“No. Even when you sign up, there’s no need to use an email address. It’s all set up so married men—and women, I supposed—can’t be accidentally discovered by their spouses.”

“Or their lawyers.”

“I suppose so.”

Jonah ducked his head under the main flow of the water to rinse off the

remaining shampoo from his hair, and came out only to hear the tail-end of her next question. “I’m sorry?” he said. “I didn’t catch that.”

“I asked how long you think Nate might have been arranging dates through that website,” she repeated.

His eyes closed as he allowed the steaming water to flow all over him, Jonah turned round to face the direction of her voice.

“I think it was a fairly new thing,” Jonah said, running his hands all over the tired muscles in his body to rinse off the soap. “It wasn’t long ago that he told me he was trying it out, anyway. How long he’d been trying it before he told me, I don’t really know.”

“Did Nate date many married women?”

“I’m not sure,” said Jonah, turning to face the wall again to shut off the water. “I never heard him talk about married women. I’m not sure I would have approved.”

“Did you ever see him with any of his dates? Or with any girlfriends?” Mulray’s voice was suddenly very clear now that the shower was no longer running.

Jonah grabbed his towel and draped it over his head to dry his hair. “A few—

ages ago. Not ones from the website.”

“What were they like? The women he went for?”

He was careful to position his towel around his nether regions as he exited the warm confines of the en suite for the open expanse of the “bedroom”, before hiding in front of the wardrobe to locate and then pull on some clean clothes.

“I don’t know. All kinds. He was always popular with the ladies.”

“But he didn’t have any particular type?”

Jonah paused in the middle of pulling on a shirt. Thinking to himself, well, if I knew that, his own investigation strategy would be easier. But

for a moment, he realized he'd always been impressed at how sharp Nate's girlfriends were. His brother had never gone for dumb-but-hot.

"I think if I had to guess, I'd say he never went for the stupid ones."

"They were bright, his girlfriends?"

"Bright, yes. I can't remember any that weren't, but we were at Oxford, you know. Most of the girls round there were fairly capable. And Nate didn't go for the locals."

"You know if he liked women to... well, take control..."

DI Mulray was seated on one of the couches as he made his way out of the bedroom dressed in a fairly simple jeans and T-shirt combination.

"What are you saying? This latest one was killed by, what, a dominatrix?"

He hovered, watching her face for the smallest clue. The police hadn't revealed any details like that. The rumors in the newspapers about the latest victim being tied up would, if true, fit such a theory.

"I couldn't possibly tell you something like that," she said, but her glance was a knowing one.

Was Mulray actually going to be a help to his unauthorized investigation, then, rather than the kind of pig-headed barrier that DI Blenin had been? That could prove interesting.

"The latest guy was tied up, that's the kind of thing a dominant woman might do," he said. Mulray remained impassive, her features set in a poker face.

"So the newspapers have speculated."

Jonah nodded, accepting that she was only following orders. He ducked into the kitchen to grab a coke from the refrigerator before finding a place on the couch opposite her.

"Your brother never said he'd received any abusive emails or messages from people on this website he used?"

“No,” Jonah said.

“And he never seemed... afraid at all, or threatened, after one of his dates?”

“Not at all. He said it was a bit of a hoot, actually. All the fun of a normal date, without any of the awkwardness of finding out whether they’re up for it or not.”

“I see.”

“I don’t think I was ever quite as... forward as my brother,” Jonah added.

The detective finished up her coffee, then reached into her jacket pocket, retrieved a business card. “I’m supposed to leave you this, I’m supposed to say that if you think of anything else you should call me.”

“Of course.”

“But you would anyway, wouldn’t you? If you happened to... remember...

anything else about what happened to Nate?”

He knew what she was inferring. You scratch my back, I’ll scratch yours. Jonah felt a little warmth inside, and it wasn’t just from the fact that the detective was so strikingly attractive behind her attempts to tone it down.

He said, “When I asked that question in the press conference, your chief was angry about what I might be inferring about Lord Moss. Were the details of his death so different from the others? Or is it just because he’s a peer?”

“I don’t know the details... there’s a lot about that one that’s being kept classified.”

Jonah squeezed his fingers into a tight fist, venting his frustration silently.

“So what about the first one—Julian Foster. He didn’t fit the same profile as Nate and this latest one, Martin what’s-his-name, but he could have been killed by the same woman?”

“Could have... but he wasn’t killed after an evening date like the others.”

“No. But maybe he met her for, you know, a quickie at lunchtime.”

Mulray sighed. “I don’t know enough about the details, I’m only a liaison officer

—and not only for these hotel killings.”

“But you must have heard a few things around the office...”

She looked out the window, silently debating what she should tell him. Then she looked at him, said, “There is a fairly solid train of thought that Lord Moss...

well, he couldn’t have possibly done anything with a woman.”

Jonah raised his eyebrows, and noticed that the detective looked a little uncomfortable at having revealed more than she had meant to.

“He was gay?” he asked.

She shook her head. “I can’t tell you any more. I’m sorry. I’ll lose my job.”

Jonah felt his mobile phone buzz in his pocket. A message from the estate agent, confirming that he was on the way with some more prospective buyers. When he looked up again, Mulray was on her feet, job done.

“Sorry,” he said. “Those guys are coming over to view the apartment.”

She nodded. “It’s probably time I made a move anyway.”

He showed her to the door, wondering if he’d get to see more of her, if she was the new liaison officer.

“I’ll call,” he said. “If I... if I remember anything.”

“Sure, keep in touch,” she replied.

The elevator was waiting for her when she touched the button. As its doors closed between them, Mulray flashed him a smile that was frankly

stunning. It seemed to cut through her otherwise professional demeanor, to really stir something within him. Then he noticed her eyes flick down, over his body, looking him over.

Wow.

What was that for? In that brief final moment, he had no doubt whatsoever that she had been checking him out.

It was only when he picked up her coffee mug and took it into the kitchen to place it in the dishwasher that he realized the wall between the kitchen area and the shower room was almost entirely transparent, thanks to a strange attempt at modernity by whichever interior designer was responsible for this place.

She'd had a prime view of everything while Jonah had been in the shower.

Five

He took the Tube up to Tufnell Park, and got there a few minutes early, since he usually factored in a little more waiting time than he'd needed for his connections.

He'd never really been to that part of North London before—it seemed pretty residential, but there appeared to be some kind of pub or nightclub up the road.

Perhaps that was where Becky would want to go.

What kind of hotel there might be around here, he had no idea. There was no point in worrying that he hadn't booked anything—she'd given him such short notice.

The time ticked by, and Jonah felt the nerves fluttering around inside his stomach. Those standard paranoid little thoughts were starting to tip-toe around his head—would she take one look at him and go home? Would he take one look at her and want to go home?

Of course, he had to face the possibility that she was a killer—otherwise, he would not be there. It was unlikely, but people did win the lottery, one-in-a-million chances did happen. Yet once again he did not feel ready to

confront a killer right now. It was only his second date, he did not feel quite prepared.

Would he ever, though? Was he putting himself unnecessarily at risk?

“Robert?”

She was behind him, coming out of the Tube station a few minutes late, taking him by surprise.

“Uh... Becky?” he turned, and there she was.

She smiled, and reached up to kiss his cheek, and Jonah felt relief wash over him

—her picture had not lied. She seemed fairly dressed down, however, which Jonah had not been expecting—wearing a simple Adidas tracksuit ensemble and

tennis shoes, her red hair tied back. It made sense, though, having come straight from her aqua aerobics class.

He concealed a smile—what had he been expecting? A nurse’s uniform on a night out?

As she kissed his cheek, he caught the slight tang of chlorine along with her delicately fruity perfume.

“I’m really sorry I’m running so late,” she apologized, and led them away in the opposite direction to the pub to which Jonah had assumed they would be going.

“No worries,” Jonah said, wondering where they were headed.

“Our instructor kept us late.”

“You work on a Saturday?” he asked, and remembered they weren’t supposed to be talking about their personal details.

Becky didn’t seem to mind, she said: “We work shifts—doesn’t really matter whether it’s a weekend or not. We’re supposed to get two days off a week, but it could be any time. I often lose track.”

“So where are we headed?” he asked.

She smiled again, looking apologetic. “Would you mind awfully if we just stuck our noses in a party?”

He shrugged, a little surprised by going with it. “Sure, whatever.”

“It’s at a friend’s flat—I haven’t seen her for ages, didn’t realize I’d promised to drop by tonight until she just texted. I really have to go, even if it’s just a few minutes.”

“Shouldn’t be a problem.”

Becky grabbed his hand, said: “I’m in a real state—didn’t even get the chance to shower after my aerobics, you must be horrified!”

“No,” he smiled, “it was in water, wasn’t it?”

He was a little surprised at her apparent casual treatment of this online dating business. She must have done it quite a bit more than he had, if she could just turn up like this all dressed down and unprepared.

They walked through a series of residential streets comprising rows of terraced housing, and Jonah again had that surreal feeling he’d had when he was with Emma, a mixture of disbelief that he was with someone so attractive and that the two of them were planning on sex despite having never met before. There was also that strange feeling that came with two complete strangers meeting like this, two entirely unconnected worlds converging in the most random way. The internet had brought a lot of changes to peoples’ lives.

He felt things tingling a little below the belt—Becky was certainly very desirable, despite her dressed-down appearance.

As they walked, she asked him a little about his work—in a polite way, more than merely inquisitive. He managed to practice some of his invented persona,

“Robert”. She appeared to believe him, but her focus was definitely distracted.

In a few minutes weaving through a maze of row houses, they arrived outside a fairly nondescript little terraced house that had loud music pumping inside, and was clearly hosting a party.

Just before ringing the bell, Becky asked him to wait.

“How do I look?” she asked once finished, looking up at him.

“Great,” he said.

“Good enough for a one night stand?” she asked with a mischievous grin.

“Absolutely,” he smiled, and they went in.

The little house was packed with people—and more than a little hot and sweaty.

They started a tour of the place, Becky showing her face around to the various people she knew, Jonah politely saying hello, though the music was too loud for any conversation to be heard.

Along the way came plenty of alcohol, which settled Jonah at first, but as they found a position to lurk in the tiny kitchen, Becky nattering to a dark-haired girl,

shot glasses were handed round and out came the tequila.

Jonah felt safe enough with Becky already—watching her at this party seemed to rule her out according to the various movie-inspired preconceptions of the anti-social serial killer.

But, as he did his best to keep conversation going with a couple of guys who were more keen to get as much tequila down him as possible, Jonah felt concerned about what might happen if he ran into the real killer incapacitated by alcohol. Refusing the booze was out of the question with the guys pushing it on him, and he could hardly walk out of there to avoid them.

And you couldn't just sip shots of tequila.

So, he tried to act more drunk than he was, and this seemed to placate them.

Well, if Becky did want to go through with the one night stand after all this, he might have to wait a while before he could fully perform at this rate.

At last, Becky pulled him away from the tequila boys. She led him back through the rest of the house, including the tiny upstairs, then to the front room to complete their little tour.

With the music now a little slower, Becky nodded towards the other couples slow dancing, and Jonah followed her into the middle, where the pretty redhead pulled him close.

“You wanna get out of here?” she asked after the music had faded into the next track, although he could only really read her lips because of the volume.

He nodded, and she led him through the throng to the narrow hallway, then out into the cool night air.

“Oh, I’m supposed to give you this,” she said, pulling a folded piece of paper from her handbag as they walked along the dark streets, Jonah without a clue as to where they were headed.

He took it, and in the streetlight made out the standardized form of a health certificate, dated a few days before. Something stirred between his legs at the apparent confirmation she still wanted to go through with all this. After all the distraction at the party, he’d almost forgotten his primary reason for being here.

“Of course,” he said, and reached for his own to give her, which she inspected as quickly as he had glimpsed at hers.

“I only live a few streets away,” she said as she handed it back to him.

There was a pause in conversation as they pressed onwards. Jonah didn’t really know what to say, it was an odd situation. What was she expecting from him—

would they have a drink or two before taking care of business, or get straight down to it? It seemed a little early in the night for this stage of a date.

“I’m sorry this has all been a bit unplanned,” Becky said, breaking the silence between them.

“It’s no problem,” Jonah said.

“I was having a really crappy day at work and felt like some company, if you know what I mean...”

“Do you do this a lot?” he asked, and as soon as the question passed his lips, he thought perhaps it was inappropriate.

“Every now and then,” she smiled. “Better than meeting someone in a pub or club usually, so.”

Again, Jonah felt his persona as “Robert” had long since slipped—maybe he needed acting lessons or something. The party and the alcohol had rendered his City Boy act a little useless. The real Jonah kept showing through.

“How about you? Seems like you just started,” she said.

Jonah shrugged, and made the decision to assume this girl was probably not a killer. “You’re my second,” he admitted.

She grinned again, full of mischief. “Well we’d better make it memorable, then.”

As soon as the front door was closed, she was all over him, pressing herself to his body, her mouth closing on his. She tasted faintly of sweet liquor as he tried to return the vigor in her kiss.

When she released him, and he could kiss down her neck a little, he found her

skin accented by chlorine from the swimming pool in which she’d had her aqua aerobics class.

“Upstairs,” she said, breathless, and broke away from his embrace, to drag him along the hallway and up two flights of stairs to the front door of an apartment.

Becky fumbled with the key a little, then forced open the door, dragging him inside after her.

In the hallway, she stopped him, and pushed him against the wall while the door closed.

“Your flatmates home?” Jonah asked.

She flashed him a grin. “Don’t have any,” she said, then he felt her hands fumbling at his belt, and her hands were suddenly inside his trousers, delving down to glide over his boxer shorts, tracing out the shape of his erect cock.

“Very nice,” she purred, and while she played with him through his underwear, caressing and squeezing, she kissed him again, her tongue somehow obscene as it ventured out into his mouth.

Without so much as a by-your-leave, she suddenly crouched, pulling down his pants and underwear as she did so, and engulfed his hardness inside the burning heat of her mouth.

He let out a low moan as he felt her tracing her tongue around the head of his cock, sucking, licking, caressing him. He looked down as she started a slow bobbing motion, watching as the crude form of his erection disappeared into her pretty, freckly face, gliding in between her velvet lips.

She took him to the brink a couple of times, but never over it.

“I’m going to get pins and needles in my toes, if I keep that up,” she said at last as she picked herself up to her feet and he pulled his pants up again. “Come on

—I’ll give you the grand tour.”

It was a tiny flat—just one bedroom, a closet of a kitchen-slash-living room, and a bathroom you could just about take a bath in. It took about 30 seconds to complete the “grand tour” and grab a glass of water from the kitchen before the

young red-headed nurse pushed him into the bedroom, in which there was hardly space to stand up around the queen-size bed.

They kissed again, and Jonah found his hands slipping underneath the waistband of her sweatpants behind her, only to find that she was apparently still wearing a one-piece swimsuit.

“Hmm... kinky, huh?” Becky joked as he slipped down her sweatpants and helped her remove her top.

“Well, it’s not a nurse’s uniform,” he said in mock regret.

Becky laughed as he nuzzled into her neck, “Please, I feel so unsexy when I’m wearing my work clothes.”

Now it was her turn to work on removing his clothing, which she dumped fairly unceremoniously on the floor.

Naked, she pushed him back on the bed, and pounced on him, pinning him down on the bed before kissing him. Jonah tried to move, but she was firm in her hold.

She was slender, but seemingly immensely strong for her build—making Jonah think that aqua-aerobics must be only scratching the surface of her exercise regime.

He did his best to roll her over, and move on top to kiss her back, but she was resistant and they wrestled, laughing as they did so.

Despite the light atmosphere between them, underneath, Jonah felt a twinge of something that was not unlike fear. He was desperately out of shape. He’d never been overweight, but the life of an academic had left him with minimal strength and conditioning. He was certain that if it came down to it, this coltish redhead could probably overpower him if she really wanted to.

He wouldn’t stand a chance if it was the actual killer he was up against.



He let her win, of course. She sat astride him as though he were some kind of mountain she’d conquered, a little out of breath but not anywhere near as out of breath as Jonah.

And so hot sitting there still in her swimsuit.

“To the victor belong the spoils!” she declared.

Jonah smiled, saying: “You can have whatever your heart desires, my lady.”

She flashed him a minx-like grin, then quickly flipped around, shuffling down to present her delectable rear in his direction, while she once again took hold of his cock. “Mmm... I think I’ll take some more of this,” she purred.

Jonah groaned again as he felt his shaft enveloped in her hot mouth. He reached up and pulled her down so he could press his face into her snatch, breathing in the spicy scent of her arousal through the moist fabric of her swimsuit. Becky cheekily wiggled her butt as he opened his mouth to press his own heat against her most sensitive region, clear in her need for attention even as she focused so much energy now on sucking his hardness.

Responding to her need, he nuzzled into her pussy, enjoying the heady mix of her perfume and her natural aroma, given an unorthodox twist by the remaining traces of chlorine, which seemed to help recall hazy mostly-forgotten adolescent fantasies of girls in the school swim team.

Trying to keep from losing his own control as she affected such glorious attention on his cock, he slipped aside the narrow band of material covering her pussy, revealing her beautiful little pink flower. Framed by a sprinkling of red down, her tidy petals glistened with juices even in the dull light of this shoebox of a bedroom.

Becky gasped as he gently touched his lips to hers, his tongue slipping out to sample her tangy cocktail. Arms reaching around her smooth round behind, he pulled her to him as he feasted on her pussy, her flesh so hot as it crushed against his mouth.

He flicked his tongue down, touching her clit to send ripples of energy through

her body that he could feel as she pressed herself down upon him. Then as she became accustomed to the contact, he focused more attention on her sensitive little button, kissing it, caressing it, swirling his tongue

around and around, sucking to draw out her increasingly insistent moans until they were close to screams.

He had no idea how long they continued. At some point she forgot completely about her end of the bargain, though she held on to his rock-hard shaft almost as if to keep her balance as she pressed her weight back, forcing her pussy against his face so that he couldn't stop even if he wanted to.

Then she was shaking, shuddering, yelling out as her release swept over her.

“Wow, where did that come from?” she said as she disengaged and slipped around to lie beside him, both of them left gasping for air.

“Good?” he asked, a little more out of breath than she was.

“Incredible. No one's ever made me feel quite like that before.”

Then she was up on her feet, leaping off the bed to step over to the little window looking out over her street. She placed her hands on the windowsill and presented her rear to him with an enticing smile.

Having softened a little in the interlude, his cock was quickly back to full strength as he picked himself up to approach her.

He slipped one strap of her swimsuit over her shoulder, but she shook her head, replacing it.

“I want to do it like this,” she growled. “I want to think about this when I go out there again for aqua-aerobics.”

Jonah couldn't help but chuckle at that idea.

“Don't laugh—the class is so dull, it's full of horrible old women. I need something to spice it up, keep me going.”

He pressed up against her, running his hands over the enticing curves of her body, over her swimsuit, to feel out the shape of her breasts enclosed by the

fabric. He could feel her nipples pressing through the material, eager to be touched. As he pressed his hard cock against her behind, preparing himself, he crushed her nipples between thumbs and forefingers, teasing out another groan or two from the ginger-haired nurse.

Then he reached down to slip aside the bathing suit just where needed so that he could enter her and relieve the urgent throbbing within his entire body. The tip of his cock touched against the searing entrance of her pussy, provoking another gasp from Becky before he eased forward, slipping inside her.

Her pussy was so tight around him as he gradually filled her, such an irresistible sensation he almost lost it there and then. He glided in, her copious juices easing the way.

“Ooh, that feels good,” she sighed as he paused a moment to revel in the sensation of her tightness fully enclosing him.

He couldn’t pause long, however, a powerful urge inside him forcing him to stir, gently withdraw and then surge forward to thrust inside her.

Soon enough, he was pounding her, spurred on by her affirmative response, feeling a little of the power that perhaps his “Robert” persona ought to have in these one night stands.

His fitness level proved less of a barrier as a raw animal drive propelled him onwards, allowing him an untapped source of energy as he pumped into her pussy, grinding the head of his cock against that secret spot that made her scream.

He was running on pure adrenaline as his own release finally came.

Afterwards, as he was on the way back out into the cool night air, she said: “You know, you could stay a while if you wanted to.”

He smiled, “You need to get some sleep before your next shift starts.”

Becky pouted, though she didn’t argue with him. It was already beginning to get light again, and after the long energetic evening together, she clearly needed to grab a few hours’ shut-eye before another long day at the hospital. This soon after his night with the never-tiring Emma, Jonah was exhausted, and badly

needed some space to crash out and sleep for ages. He knew the website encouraged the kind of abrupt liaison where it was expected you'd walk away after the sex, but as the exhaustion started really setting in, he had been worried he might hurt her feelings by just leaving.

She was surprisingly accepting of it, though, which reminded him she'd done this before several times.

"Hey no worries—that's fine. At least you didn't just sneak out," she said when he'd finally tentatively suggested it might be time to make a move. "Besides, Rory's flight should touch down soon."

"Rory?"

She grinned as she opened the door for him. "My husband. Probably shouldn't have said."

Jonah felt his breath forcibly evacuated from his lungs. Her husband?

"Don't look so shocked," she giggled. "Everyone does it nowadays, don't they?"

"I... uh... of course..." Jonah felt crushed, that he had facilitated adultery like this. But wasn't it par for the course with the No Strings website? Apparently.

"Would it make you feel better if I said my husband's okay with it?"

He looked at her, and remembered that he was supposed to be Robert the City trader, not Jonah the mild-mannered academic.

"Hey, it's none of my business," he said affecting a coolness that seemed to please her. He couldn't feel too guilty—she hadn't revealed her marital status until after he'd slept with her. She wasn't wearing a ring, though it hadn't really been something he'd looked for beforehand. The diminutive size of her flat had also given him the impression that she was single—but then this was London.

One-car garages were sold for six-figure sums in this town.

The redhead smiled warmly across the threshold, then leaned up to kiss him.

“You’re really amazing, Robert,” she said. “Completely not what I was expecting from your profile.”

He nodded, “It’s hard to get those things right, huh?”

“Maybe we could see each other again some time?”

“I’d like that.”

It was as easy a parting as could have been, really. As he walked away, he felt a shard of something inside him that might have been his natural monogamous nature craving a return to the sweetness of her embrace. He’d have to get used to that. Learning the difference between lust and love.

The streets were empty as he threaded his way back towards the main road where he suspected he’d be able to get a night bus. The Tube wasn’t open for another couple of hours, he thought, so the bus was his best bet.

On his way, however, a couple of occasions he thought he saw movement out of the corner of his eye. When he turned his head, he could see nothing out of the ordinary.

A little further on, he rounded the corner and again thought there was some movement in the shadows down the street. This time he stopped, even backtracked a few steps. Nothing.

He was beginning to get the eerie sensation that he was being followed.

Six

It was weird, just plain weird. Seeing that gravestone wrenched his insides out every time.

Rounding the corner into the last row of plots, skirting under the sleepy yew tree, and there it was, stark, ghastly. The letters chiseled into smart granite were so cold, so sharp, somehow, stabbing straight through his heart whenever he laid eyes on them.

Nate Robert Fielding.

Standing there, feeling that burning hole inside him, the anguish was still intense every time he came here. The tears burned like acid as they filtered out from around his eyes. The nausea made him want to heave.

The unbelievable sorrow squeezed his heart like a vice.

And yet he had to go there, to feel that connection again, the bond of brothers—

or at least a hint of what it had once been. Even months after the fact, Jonah felt a huge part of himself was missing. Visiting Nate like this made him remember what it felt like to be whole.

He didn't believe in the after life. He and his brother had been brought up as Christians, but not as particularly fervent ones. His scientific education had, perhaps, seen him drifting away from any semblance of faith—but Nate's shocking death had proved the final hammer blow. Perhaps strangely, so many times since it had all happened he wished that he was religious, he even felt envious of people who had that faith. It was easy for them, to simply embrace the idea that their love ones were in paradise after they passed away.

It wasn't so easy to be an atheist when your nearest and dearest died. A life of devotion to the church suddenly seemed like the easy option when the alternative was to know in your heart that your loved one had simply ceased to exist, their spirit extinguished, everything that they were, everything that they had achieved,

everything that they had become wasted.

The only consolation was in the memories—the only place where Nate lived on.

Keeping the memories alive was the only comfort possible.

When it was time to leave again, Jonah always took away an ounce of comfort from his visit. In part, it was what kept him coming back.

On this occasion, though, as he quietly wandered back through the rows of silent stones, marking the final resting places of so many people, Jonah saw a familiar face sitting patiently on a bench, not even looking in his

direction as though she'd drifted off to sleep with her large, pretty brown eyes still open.

"Are you following me, Detective?"

She turned to look at him, relaxed, serene, not remotely concerned if, indeed, she had been tailing him.

"Mr Fielding," she gave him a quick up-and-down with those beautiful eyes of hers, and made him wonder if the two buttons on her blouse that were unfastened—sufficient for him to see not only a hint of her cleavage, but even a small glimpse of her white lace bra—were entirely appropriate for a police detective on duty, let alone sitting in a cemetery.

Her blouse didn't seem to quite fit with the nature of someone who took such obvious care with her appearance—and who ordinarily attempted to downplay her femininity to fit with the male-bias of her professional environment.

"Jonah, please," he said. Then, "Are you here in a professional capacity?"

She smiled, but there was pity in her eyes, empathy. She nodded, flicked her eyes further along the path. Jonah followed her gaze, and saw an elegantly-dressed woman, kneeling at a graveside some distance away, arranging a small bunch of white flowers.

The woman initially looked to be his age, though as Jonah stared at her, he thought perhaps she was older. Something in her poise, her dignity, suggested someone a little more world-weary than his first impression.

"You're here for her?" he asked, surprised at the coincidence.

"Lily Foster," Mulray said.

Jonah nodded at his recognition of the name. "Wife of the first victim," he said quietly. He wondered if the flowers she was laying on her husband's grave were lilies. "She often come to visit at this time of the week?"

One edge of Mulray's mouth curled up in a smile, "First time she's been here since the funeral," she said.

“You suggested this particular moment might be a good time for her first return here?”

The detective shrugged, “I’m only the liaison officer, it’s not for me to keep tabs on everyone’s schedules to keep victims’ relatives away from each other.”

“You think I might have something to say to her?” he asked Mulray.

“I’m sure I don’t have any idea.”

“You think it might be useful for me to talk to her?”

“If you were asking me hypothetically, I’d say you’ve both been through a traumatic experience, and that might mean you can empathize with each other, sure.”

Jonah felt the breeze shift, and suddenly he caught a chestful of her sweet coconut scent. God. Be still my beating heart, he thought.

“You imagine there’s something I might find out from her, that perhaps you police detectives can’t?”

Mulray casually sniffed and changed the subject. “You’ve been trying out a little online dating, then,” she said.

Jonah felt a little pang of surprise that she knew about his dating. “Have you been following me?” he said, trying to keep the emotions out of his voice, not wanting to give himself away like that.

“Why would I want to do something as time-consuming as that?”

He looked at her, not buying it.

“I can see why you might get frustrated...”

“If the police aren’t taking it seriously, someone should.”

“But dating your way around London to try and flush her out?” Mulray’s voice took on a sharp edge. “Are you serious?”

The idea did sound a little on the ridiculous side. He said, “It’s not ideal, but it’s something. As I find out more about the kind of women Nate was dating, it’ll help me refine the strategy.”

Mulray offered him an eye-roll. “Even if it doesn’t take forever, you think if you did happen to ask the killer out on a date, somehow you would be able to defend yourself where everybody else has failed?”

She had a point, of course, but how could she possibly understand his thinking, she was not standing in his shoes.

“I’ll take precautions,” he said, but the detective did not seem convinced.

Jonah saw Lily Foster stand up now, turn to walk back toward the police liaison officer, one eyebrow rising slightly, curious as to who it was speaking with Mulray.

Mulray sighed, said: “Do something for me, would you?”

“Sure.”

“Keep a journal. Or something like that. Write down every detail you can about the dates you go on—including while you’re on the date, if you can. You have a smart phone, don’t you?”

“Of course.”

“So then. Give me—or someone else that you trust—some way of accessing your notes in the event that something bad does happen.”

Jonah stared into her eyes. Would he want her to know all the details of his

dates? Who else did he know that he could provide such information to, if all went wrong? It was a sound idea, though. If he was cataloging everything about a date, and she did attempt something, it might provide valuable clues to the authorities.

“I’ll work something out,” he said.

Mulray nodded. Lily Foster was coming toward them now, and Jonah saw that as she approached, she did appear to be a few years older than him,

perhaps even nearing 40. She was, though, a strikingly attractive woman.

“Your dating strategy—you might do better looking at the types of women the other victims dated,” the detective said quietly. “Not just Nate.”

“You’d be able to help me talk to the other relatives?”

She shook her head. “Not in my job description, Mr Fielding. I’d probably be suspended for doing something like that.”

Jonah took a deep breath, thinking to himself: and yet here am I, standing in a cemetery with none other than Lily Foster, wife of the first victim. Serene and solemn, she had a pale yet pretty face framed by long reddish-brown hair, and soulful brown eyes that could have entranced the hardest of hearts.

“Hi,” she said, offering him a smile born of uncertainty regarding who he was, and what he might be doing accompanying DI Mulray. “Are you with the police as well?”

“Uh... no,” he said, swallowing involuntarily. If she really was a man-eater, men stood no chance. “Actually, I was here visiting my brother, Nate.”

Lily nodded. “You’re Jonah,” she said, and in glancing at Mulray, Jonah could see the lights in her intelligent eyes as she worked out the detective’s little ploy of bringing her here in order to accidentally meet the brother of another murder victim.

“Yes,” he said simply, not quite knowing what to say.

“I’m sorry for your loss.”

“Yes, likewise.” He looked at Mulray, wondering if he ought to be asking Lily Foster questions about her husband—presumably about whether he was cheating on her, what kind of women he might have dated if he had. It didn’t seem appropriate, not for this place, and not for a conversation in the presence of the police.

Was he supposed to ask for her number? It all seemed more than awkward.

Breaking the awkward pause, Mulray said: “Well, we’d better be going.”

“Yes. Well, it was nice to meet you, Jonah,” Lily said.

“Likewise,” Jonah replied, feeling immensely foolish for being completely clueless as to what to say to her.

He watched them walking away, and felt completely baffled as to what Mulray had meant by this briefest of introductions.

Seven

It was 10 days after seeing Becky that Jonah had his next encounter through the No Strings website. During that time, two potential ‘dates’ had turned into nothing—one had failed to turn up at all, while another had canceled the night before.

He didn’t blame them, didn’t feel bad about it. Jonah knew well enough how terrifying it was meeting up with complete strangers, even after introductions by email. It had to be worse for young women, too. Their vulnerability in these situations.

The killer Jonah was pursuing had been targeting young men, however.

Tonight, Jonah was waiting for another date at a table in the enclosed area outside Brown’s, a bar-restaurant housed in a converted old brick warehouse on the gentrified dockside, just a stone’s throw from Nate’s actual apartment. He was hopeful he wasn’t facing a third strike in a row.

From his correspondence with tonight’s date, someone who called herself Jessica, he was fully expecting her to show. She was more of a forceful type than others he had corresponded with through the website. Recently, he’d been actively seeking out a few dominant personalities in the women he’d been adding to his ‘interested’ list. Thinking he ought to be pushing the boundaries if he wanted any hope of catching up with Nate’s killer.

She had to be at least a little dominant if she was the killer, right?

His two successful ‘dates’ so far had been fun, but he couldn’t see Emma or Becky in the role of murderer.

Tonight, he already had a feeling things were going to be different.

To start with, Jonah was projecting a sharper image this evening. He had spent the morning carefully looking through Nate's wardrobe, and though he had still

found himself too freaked out to actually wear any of it, it had proved useful research for a subsequent shopping excursion. He really had to fit the look if he wanted people to believe he was a City trader like his brother. He now sat in a designer suit, smart tie and shirt, and spotless leather brogues.

Secondly, it was a much later start than his previous encounters—9pm, on the dot.

Jonah was nervous again. It didn't seem to get easier this online dating, though he wasn't really very experienced in it yet. The waiting was the worst part—

once she arrived, once he knew what he was up against, it wasn't so bad. The uncertainty chewed into his stomach walls.

He examined the female faces walking by outside the restaurant, and the few wandering around the tables inside this little enclosure. Down here on the dockside, there was a row of relatively large restaurants, all converted from an old brick warehouse. Lots of people around, even for a mid-week night. None of them seemed to be looking for Jonah.

What did he know about her? She was called Jessica, she was 29 years old, two years older than he was. She worked in the City and had a team of 10 traders underneath her, revealing in her profile that she liked telling arrogant men what to do.

Their brief email exchange had not added an awful lot of color to his knowledge of her. She'd ignored his questions for the most part, though asked him some: if he could handle a strong-willed woman, if he'd get scared off by someone telling him what to do, if he gave good head.

Faces drifting by—none of them looking for anyone.

She was ten minutes late. He'd already finished his beer, but couldn't afford to leave his station to get another. There didn't appear to be enough waiting staff to actually reach his table, either.

For a moment, he half-recognized the back of someone's head, or thought he did.

He knew it wasn't Jessica, she being a blonde according to her website, not a brunette. She didn't turn, didn't show her face. Maybe he was just being paranoid. There had been a couple of times in the past week where he got the feeling he was being tailed, but when he'd turned to look, tried to alter his route

to catch out his shadow, it had come to zip.

"Robert?"

He turned to find a waiter—a male one at that—bearing a large tray with only a single shot glass perched in the middle of it. Not Jessica, then. Was someone playing a prank on him?

"Yes? That's me."

The waiter gave a quick nod. "I was asked to give you a message—and this drink."

"Okay."

"She said you should drink this and then find her in the parking garage round back, across the street."

The waiter leaned in to offer up the small glass of clear liquid, and Jonah felt no option but to take it.

"Thanks," he said. "Did she say anything about where she'd be in the garage?"

"She only gave me this to give you," he said, fumbling in a pocket in his white apron before handing a small silver-and-black object to Jonah.

"Oh."

It was a key, quite plainly a car ignition key, complete with a small black plastic unit for opening a vehicle's central locking system.

“That’s all I got, mate,” the waiter said, holding up a palm to indicate he was now done, message passed, job complete.

“Thanks,” Jonah said, shaking his head at a final offer of another drink before the waiter withdrew to serve a nearby table.

Well, this was different. He had to go find her. In a parking lot. He vaguely knew there was one around the back of this building, attached to the Cineworld movie theater. What, was he supposed to go around pressing the button on the key, see

which car it unlocked? Did this mean they were going to drive somewhere?

Jonah looked at the shot glass he held between thumb and forefinger. What if it was poison? Drugs, perhaps, to dull his senses, make him compliant.

He recalled nothing from any newspaper report or police interview on TV to suggest the killer had used poison or drugs on her victims. Still, there wasn’t any hard and fast rule that a murderess had to stick to her exact same Modus Operandi all the way through a murder spree.

The fact that a waiter had handed him the glass seemed to suggest to Jonah it was just a drink.

He had to take it on trust. Do what he was told. She was softening him up, that was clear.

With a deep breath, he touched the glass to his bottom lip, then upended it, tilting his head back as he threw the ice-cold liquid into his mouth. Fire hit the back of his throat as he swallowed, wincing as much at the strong aniseed taste as at the bite of the strong alcohol.

Jonah sat for a few moments, waiting. Feeling the liquor warming his insides as it filtered through into his bloodstream. God, it had been strong. He didn’t remember drinking anything like that. Absinthe was green, though, wasn’t it? It couldn’t have been that.

If she’d drugged him, or poisoned him, how would it make him feel? It couldn’t be a fast-acting reagent, if she wanted him to go find her in the

parking lot. But, sitting there a few minutes, he began to feel confident enough to make a move.

Rising to his feet, he felt the powerful alcohol take a little of the edge off his balance, though it had also softened some of the nervous flicker inside his stomach.

It was a short walk around the end of the building to the parking lot.

He entered via the most obvious entrance of the place, assuming this was where he would be expected to enter. It was beginning to get dark, lending the rows of cars and the stark concrete of the structure an air of menace.

A few paces inside, and he tried the button, not really expecting anything.

Expecting her to want to put him in his place and make him search for her.

To his surprise, he heard a bleat from a car alarm, responding to the signal. It must have been a powerful system—it sounded as though the vehicle was a floor down, and some way away.

Jonah walked into the direction of the alarm, feeling more than a little intimidated by his surroundings. He could feel his heart pulsing inside his chest, his step seeming to fall in line with his pulse.

Then he rounded a concrete pillar and saw her. He caught his breath.

She was leaning up against a large silver Mercedes—a beautiful blonde with violent red lipstick, her hair tied back in a long, tidy ponytail, she appeared to be about Jonah's age or thereabouts. Wearing clothes fit for the office—white blouse, suit skirt falling to just above her knees, black tights or stockings, and the kind of high-heeled shoes that could have killed a man.

Her picture on the website hardly did her justice.

She nodded her head once, twice, ordering him to her.

Jonah took a deep breath, wondering if this young woman could be a killer. Was she going to drive him somewhere? Somewhere he'd have no

chance of defense?

Suddenly, he longed for the bland comforts of a hotel room.

“Robert?”

He nodded.

She gestured for him to approach her, and as he did, felt her eyes trailing all over him, assessing him, checking out his threads and what might lie underneath them.

“Hi,” he said, coming within a few feet of her, breathing in a chestful of her exotic perfume.

She did not return his greeting. There was no air-kiss, no pleasantries. She just pointed to the ground, face neutral, impassive. There was a beat where Jonah

wrinkled his brow in confusion, but he hazarded a guess as to what she was telling him, and kneeled before her.

He felt like an obedient puppy, but there was something darkly thrilling to kneel on the concrete floor, face inches away from her shapely nylon-clad legs, waiting for her next command.

It seemed to him that she was still deciding on him, perhaps there would be a test before she either took him somewhere, or rejected him.

Now she eased up the hem of her skirt ever so slowly, revealing that her upper thighs were clad in the elegant black lace of stocking tops, held by suspenders.

Jonah stifled a gasp as she continued drawing up her skirt, and he detected a hint of spice in the air along with her perfume. Jessica was not wearing panties, so there was her pussy, right in front of him, without so much as a ‘how do you do’.

If he hadn’t been hard before, he was now. Brutally so. She had a beautiful pussy to go along with everything else, with a tidy patch of blonde hair on her mound, and pink pussy lips glistening with her

moisture. Jonah breathed in the scent of her arousal, gazing in awe at the sight before him.

“Show me what you can do,” she said firmly.



He leaned forward, hands flat to the ground in front of him, wondering for a moment whether he was in a position to cut and run if things did turn dangerous.

He took another long, slow breath filled with her scent, but whether or not she perceived it as hesitation, she clearly did not intend him to take his time. She grabbed him by the hair and now pulled him to her, his face colliding with the raw heat of her hot, wet pussy.

She tasted sharp and salty, but Jonah was given little time or space to appreciate her. He extended his tongue, but it was Jessica who controlled the movement of her pussy on his face—using him, caring little how forcefully she held his head, or crushed her searing folds against his face.

Jonah could only hang on and go with the flow, licking her, sucking her where he was able. He wondered if she worked out regularly—she seemed strong, and holding him with both her hands, it felt as though there was no way he could escape now other than fully satisfying her.

Was this what Nathan had experienced before the end? A loss of control?

All manner of dark thoughts passed through Jonah’s mind as he put every ounce of his energy into pleasuring this beautiful, frightening woman.

Then she was shuddering on top of him, the pressure of her weight on his face lightening, and her pussy was gliding over him lubricated by copious juices. She was quivering, trembling, rocking, and he could tell she was making special effort not to cry out.

“Thank you,” was all she said, pushing him away, allowing her skirt to fall back in place to cover her crotch.

Jonah watched in astonishment as she quietly stepped around to get in her car, and fire up the engine.

He had to get quickly out of the way to make sure she didn't hit him as she made her exit.



Watching her drive off, her taste smeared over his face, Jonah felt a little used and somehow more alive than he'd felt in ages. His cock was so hard in his pants, still, that it was a wonder he hadn't had a leakage problem.

Wow.

He took a moment to pull himself together, feeling a little unsteady as he straightened up on his feet once again, before he ventured back out of the parking lot. What a strange encounter. Perhaps that was all too common when you were using a website to arrange sexual encounters—it didn't necessarily mean a romantic candle-lit dinner and a comfortable bed in a nice hotel.

As he wandered back towards the bar on the quayside, he licked his lips, tasting her again, bringing the sharp lines of her attractive face back to mind. Would he ever see her again? Would it be dangerous if he did see her again?

He'd never been with a woman like that before. What an amazing thrill it was to be used solely for her pleasure like that. Her pussy clamping down on his mouth so intimately.

And in the public parking lot—it all seemed so wrong, yet so exhilarating.

If he went back into the bar, would other people detect her on him? The smell of her sex? Yet he needed a stiff drink.

He spotted an empty table outside, and decided that since Brown's had table service, he was safer to grab a seat and remain outside.

Waiting for his drink, he found himself thinking of ways to adjust his profile on the No Strings website to perhaps attract women like Jessica.

But was he thinking of doing that for his own sexual exploration, or because he genuinely thought the murderer was that kind of woman?

He felt a pang of guilt as a waitress made her way towards him, that his trawling through the seedy sex site was perhaps mainly about his own distractions—

taking his mind off the terrible pain of losing his brother—than actively making a difference in the pursuit of justice.

“Jonah!”

The voice startled him.

He turned his head to see the familiar sight of Emma across a few tables, sitting with a gaggle of other people who looked like students. She was dressed in a fairly ordinary jacket and jeans combination—chic enough, though not like the little black dress he’d last seen her in.

As his eyes connected with hers, her face lit up at the confirmation it was him, and he felt a little tingle in his loins at the memory from the last time they’d met.

She uttered a few words of explanation to her group of friends, and hauled herself up to pick her way through the tables over to him.

He stood up to greet her, and suddenly feared she would be able to sense the lingering traces of Jessica on him as she approached. There was no avoiding her, though.

“What are you doing here?” she demanded, her mouth stretched wide in a broad smile. “You look very smart.”

“I live here,” he shrugged in return, as she now reached up to kiss his cheek as though he were an old friend, his lungs swamped with her coconut-tinged perfume.

“Or should I call you ‘Robert’?” she said under her breath, eyes sparkling with mischief.

He sat back down, but Emma stayed hovering on her feet beside him. She suddenly caught her breath, thinking of something, and said: “You’re not waiting for another... date... are you?”

Jonah smiled and shook his head. “No,” he said. “Honestly—I do live here. Over there, in fact.”

He nodded over towards the tall apartment building housing the Marriott Hotel over next to the Docklands Light Railway track.

“Very nice,” she said, and briefly glanced over at her friends, perhaps to check

they weren’t demanding her back, before pulling out the chair next to Jonah’s and dropping herself down on it.

“It was my brother’s,” Jonah said, thinking it no longer such a problem to reveal his personal information to her, since she’d already had a perusal of his wallet to find out his real identity. “He... passed away recently. I’m just staying there until I can sort out his affairs.”

“Oh, I’m so sorry,” she said, offering him genuine pity.

He nodded appreciatively, said: “I suppose that’s why I tried that dating site, you know? Take my mind off things.”

The waitress now brought him a pint of beer as requested, and he asked Emma if she wanted a drink.

“Oh no, I’ve had plenty,” she said. “Far too much already tonight.”

Jonah gulped half his drink—desperately in need of the liquid.

“Don’t feel pressure to catch up,” Emma joked as he put the drink back down on the table. “So have you had any more... dates... since ours?”

“A couple,” he said. “It’s actually a lot harder to set them up than I first appreciated, I think. You must have been...”

“Beginner’s luck?”

“Something like that. Have you... had any more... dates?” he wondered if it was bad form to pry into her own affairs.

She smiled. “Actually no, but I was beginning to think about trying it again some time—you know, the fires a-burning!”

Now without asking, she took a sip from Jonah’s own drink.

“Are you here on your own, then?” she asked him.

“I was having a drink with a friend, but she had to leave.”

“Having a drink with a friend wearing a sophisticated suit?” Emma grinned,

“Don’t tell me you didn’t measure up, Jonah! I don’t think I’d believe that.”

“It wasn’t - “

“Unless she was expecting someone like ‘Robert’ to appear, of course,” the blonde teased him. Jonah just drank some more beer. “I can’t say I was disappointed that ‘Robert’ didn’t turn up, though. You were quite a nice surprise.”

“Thank you,” he said, feeling a little warmth blooming inside his chest.

He saw now that Emma’s friends were getting up from their table, apparently readying to leave. Yet she wasn’t in the slightest bit put out when he warned her.

“They’re losers, that’s all,” she grinned. “I thought it might be nice to give you some company.”

“I wouldn’t say no.”

“You could show me your apartment if you liked,” she said.

Jonah took another gulp of beer, and felt the hardness throb between his thighs.

Was she saying what he thought she was saying? It seemed ridiculous to him—

this girl was so pretty, how could she possibly be interested in an average joe like him?

And if she was truly interested, he was worried she'd be able to tell he'd been with Jessica if she did start getting friendly with him back at the flat. Would he get away with saying he needed a shower?

He said: "I'd be happy to give you the tour—but you know what they're saying in the newspapers at the moment?"

"What are they saying?" her eyes flashed with lust.

"There's a dangerous, sexy woman going around killing guys she meets on dates."

Emma giggled. "And you think I'm dangerous and sexy?"

For some reason best known to herself, Emma did accompany him back to his apartment. After the abrupt end to his 'date' with Jessica, if that was her name, Jonah did feel the hardness between his legs affecting his agenda to a large extent.

If Emma wanted a reprisal of their act together, what problem was there?

They left the bar some time after Emma's friends had gone, and as it was getting late, there were no longer too many people around out there on the quay—at Brown's or the other bars along the dockside.

Jonah caught that curious sense of being watched, or being followed again on the brief walk along to his building. It was just paranoia, though. Had to be. He had paranoid thoughts running rampant.

Eight

By the time the elevator had reached Nate's apartment, Emma was all over him, and Jonah was too distracted to worry about her being a killer, or that she might detect his evening's activity with a mysterious Mercedes driver.

Her kiss was so forceful, she pressed him back against the wall of the elevator, her hands sprawling over him as she sucked on his lips and delved her tongue into his mouth.

Only the bell and the opening elevator door could make her stop.

“Which one’s yours?” she demanded, dragging him out into the hallway, then prompted by a little flick of his head, pulling him over to the apartment front door where he could enter the code in the keypad.

“Very nice,” she said, letting go of his hand as she wandered into the cavernous apartment.

Jonah had got rid of a few pieces of furniture on eBay recently, and he thought it made the place seem even bigger.

He flicked on the lights, and Emma whirled on her feet and ordered him to turn them back off. “I like it when it’s all lit up by the city,” she said, now peeling off her jacket to drape it over the back of the nearest couch.

“Fair enough,” he said, extinguishing the lights as requested.

With the huge great floor-to-ceiling windows, there was still a lot of light in that apartment, albeit within a bluish tint. Canary Wharf and the buildings across the water had a lot of lights blazing, even though nobody was in there working at this hour.

He gave her a quick explanation of where things were—bedroom, bathroom, kitchen—though with the open plan layout, it was all fairly self explanatory.

Emma didn’t really seem interested in looking around much—instead, she simply launched herself on him again, nearly knocking him off his feet as she jumped on him, legs wrapping around his thighs, arms flung around his neck, her lips crushing against his as she tasted his mouth again.

Jonah held her and for the second time that evening felt he could do little but go with the flow, allow her to take what she wanted from him.

They were breathless as she eventually broke off. She said: “You taste a little funny, you know that? Salty.”

“It’s been a long night,” he fumbled. “I could take a shower...”

“No,” she said, stepping back, her eyes seeming to scan his face as her mind attempted to process the clues. She said: “One of your dates was tonight, wasn’t it?”

Jonah sighed. Well, he’d been greedy to suppose that his abbreviated ‘date’ could be made up thanks to a chance encounter with Emma. Now she’d find out the truth and high-tail it out of there.

“It wasn’t really a date...” he said, wondering how much he should tell her, if there was any way he could salvage this situation.

“She screwed you, didn’t she?”

“I... well...”

But Emma did not flee. He saw to his surprise a curious smile spread across her face as she stepped back towards him, pulling him to her by his lapels before saying: “You stink of sex, Jonah.”

Then she licked his face.

“I love it!” she declared, pulling him in for another kiss on the mouth, then mottling his face with more kisses. “Tell me about her—was she pretty?”

“Very,” he said, brow creasing in bemusement at her reaction.

“Let me guess—brunette?”

He shook his head. “Blonde, not too different from you, actually.”

She grinned, and now took hold of the bottom of her dark t-shirt, which had been red under the lights within the bar, but appeared gray in the blue tint of the apartment windows. Then she pulled it up and off over her head, revealing a simple white bra containing her small but shapely breasts, as though in punishment for a wrong guess.

“She was older than me, though, wasn’t she?” Emma asked him now.

“She was. About my age.”

The petite blonde looked satisfied she was right, and now unfastened the buttons on his shirt, before removing it—only to leave his tie in place. His skin rose up in goose bumps from the cool conditioned air.

“Did she take you to a hotel?”

Jonah shook his head. Emma kicked off her shoes to reveal little feet in little white socks.

“You brought her back here?”

Again, he shook his head, smiling this time at confirmation that this had turned into a game. This time, the blonde removed the belt from around her jeans as recompense for her wrong answer.

Emma grinned herself, asking: “She took you to her place?”

But he shook his head a third time, leaving her baffled, removing her socks for her penance.

“What then?” Emma demanded. “I know you licked her pussy, Jonah. You’re so filthy like that.”

Now, for a change, he nodded, and kicked off his shoes in recognition of her correct statement. It made her laugh.

Apparently delighted, she said: “God that’s so disgusting. I bet you went in the ladies’ in that bar or something, shoved her into a cubicle and devoured her.”

He shook his head, and this time Emma tugged open the fly of her jeans, and pulled them down her slender thighs to reveal a fairly plain but nevertheless sexy little pair of thong panties that matched her white bra.

Jonah thought he could see goose bumps on her skin as well, though it didn’t detract from her breathtaking beauty.

She was determined: “Where was it? Around here somewhere?”

“Yes,” he said, removing his socks now. How long should this go on, this Q-andA? He threw her a bone, saying: “It was in the parking lot, behind the cinema.”

She gasped, said: “By Cineworld? That’s revolting. Inside a parked car?”

Jonah shook his head. Emma reached behind her back and unfastened her bra, flashing him another mischievous smile as her perky breasts were exposed, complete with nipples that were seriously stiff.

God, she looked like a goddess standing in the half-light, in nothing but a pair of skimpy white panties.

“Outside of a parked car?” she said, one eyebrow raised in mock-outrage.

Jonah pulled off his tie, leaving her giggling.

“You licked her pussy out in the open, up against a parked car,” she said, hands on hips as though disapproving.

“It’s what she wanted,” he said, now removing his suit pants.

“And then you fucked her?” she asked, “Out there up against a car?”

“No,” he said, “It didn’t go that far. I made her come, and then she went.”

The pretty blonde was laughing as she slipped her panties down her thighs, to reveal her irresistibly cute little pussy under a light sprinkling of down. She tossed her panties to him, telling him he was obviously too much sweetness for some girls.

“Am I too much sweetness for you?” Jonah said, pressing her panties to his nose

briefly to breathe in that dark tickle of her arousal that had moistened the soft cotton.

“Oh, I have a real sweet tooth,” she purred, and now grabbed hold of his hand once again, to pull him over to the bed.



She made him reenact his efforts with Jessica, of course, to more than satisfy her curiosity. It was fairly bizarre for a second time in one

evening, yet as the pretty 22-year-old pointed out, other than her forcefulness it wasn't too far from what he'd done with Emma the moment they'd gotten into the Thistle Hotel on their first date.

"Face it, dear, you just have a knack for it," she said breathlessly after becoming the second woman in a night to come spectacularly over his face.

Had he enjoyed it more with Emma? Hard to say. It was different. He liked Emma more as a person, obviously, not knowing much at all about his first 'date'

of the evening. That perhaps made it more pleasurable bringing her pleasure.

Emma had a different scent, a different flavor. Softer, somehow; lighter, sweeter.

The blonde now pushed him away from her, as Jessica had before her, only this time he was happy to flop back on the mattress. Then she went over to the window to check out the impressive view over the West India Quay and across to the tall, crystal-and-steel towers of Canary Wharf.

"Your brother must have been pretty well-off," she said, standing there, hands pressed up against the glass, apparently unconcerned that anyone out there might look up and see her nudity.

"He was," Jonah said. "They're paid quite well in the City, you know. He always said people burn out at 35 though, so it was a case of making hay while the sun was shining."

"You probably don't want to talk about him, huh?" she said, turning to him, an apology in her eyes.

Jonah shrugged, and now got up to stroll over to the central island of the kitchen.

"It's no problem," he said, actually feeling good to talk to somebody, even a relative stranger. "It's hard not to find a moment where I'm not thinking about him—avoiding talking about it isn't going to stop me obsessing about it."

“D’you mind if I ask how... how he passed away?”

Glass of iced water in hand, he approached her now. She was facing him, leaning

back to press her naked butt up against the glass. If anyone was watching now, they’d be getting quite a sight. Perhaps with the subject of discussion, he felt there were more important things than worrying about whether anyone out there could see his nakedness as he now drew close to Emma again.

Answering her, he said simply, brutally: “He was stabbed four times.”

Emma gasped. “Like one of the - “

Jonah nodded, “Hotel murder victims.”

“Oh God, I’m so sorry - “

“What can you do?”

She hugged him tight for a moment or two, before he suggested they talk about something else.

“What d’you want to talk about?” she asked.

“I don’t know,” he said, now he worried that any kind of jollity was now lost for good.

She said: “Before, you said you’d been on a couple of dates since ours.”

“That’s right,” he agreed.

“Who was the other one?”

“Becky,” he said, wondering if it was against the rules to talk about ‘No Strings’

dates with other dates from the same website. “She was a nurse from Tufnell Park.”

“A nurse!” the blonde grinned broadly, her eyes blazing. “Very saucy. How far did you go with her?”

“All the way,” he said, feeling funny about talking about it, but at the same time feeling his loins tingling again.

“What did you do with her?” she said, and now dropped down into a crouch in front of him, her hands sliding down the sides of his body to find his thickening

cock.

“She took me to a mad house party,” he said, then let out a little moan as Emma licked his growing hardness from base to tip. “I had to pose briefly as her boyfriend—but then we went back to her place.”

“Her place? Wow. Very trusting. What happened when you got there?”

It was hard to concentrate on forming words as she planted long, lingering kisses over the tip of his cock and around his shaft. “Oh you know, this and that,” he said, but she looked up at him with a sharp expression.

“Well, she did a little of what you’re doing,” he said. He wasn’t really one to talk dirty.

She flashed her eyes, and then sank on his shaft, surrounding him in the impressive heat of her soft mouth.

“Was she wearing her uniform?” Emma asked him in a momentary break from sucking his cock.

“No—she’d been at aqua aerobics before we hooked up—she was still wearing her swimming stuff.”

“Shame. If you get a second date you should get her to wear her uniform. That would be hot. Was she attractive, your nurse?”

“Very. Redhead—lots of freckles, but I always liked that.”

“You’re going to make me jealous,” Emma teased, but then bobbing down on his cock again, all conversation halted as she now focused on his

hardness.

She took him close to his peak, but not over it.

Then as he found himself trying to avoid coming in her mouth, he looked out of the window and on the far side of the quay, down by the Iberica restaurant, caught sight of a flash of light.

He gasped, and with Emma slowing down, it was clear he wasn't gasping from her efforts.

"What is it?" she asked, turning to look in the direction he was gazing.

"Down there," he said. "I thought I saw... I think someone's looking up at us through binoculars."

Then from where the flash had come, he saw a tiny dark figure dash into the shadows of the nearby building on Cabot Square.

Emma stood, and put her hands on the glass again as she peered down in the direction Jonah pointed.

"On that side of the water?" she asked.

"I think whoever it was has gone now."

"You really think someone was watching this particular apartment?"

"It looked like they were."

The delectable blonde now tilted her hips to offer up her shapely behind to him.

She said: "Don't you think we ought to give whoever it is a real show?"

How could Jonah resist such an offer?

He figured that whatever that flash had been, chances were it hadn't been someone watching this flat. And if it was, what could they really see from so far away?

Sidling up to her now, he crouched briefly to take another taste of her succulent and soaking pussy before rising to guide the tip of his hard cock to her entrance, pausing to caress the hot, velvet flesh around her wetness before at last putting her out of her misery to lunge forward, filling her with his swollen shaft.

Remembering how hard she liked it from behind, he thrust into her increasingly forcefully, until he was really hammering into her, his body beating a powerful rhythm against her firm behind as she cried out in the darkness.

The next time he caught another glint that he realized was light reflected off a lens that could well have been watching them, Jonah was too close to exploding his hot seed inside the petite blonde to really care.

As far as he was concerned, whoever it was could happily witness this moment as he fucked this seriously sexy little blonde hard, taking her to another riotous orgasm before he emptied his hot oil inside her.



Later, they lay awake in bed, and Emma asked him if his dating through the No Strings website was related to his brother's murder.

Perhaps it was only an innocent question, but for some reason it disturbed him.

Did Emma know something she wasn't saying?

"What led you to that conclusion?" he asked her, concealing his surprise at her question.

"The newspapers say the killer is some sexy chick that dates a lot of men—and after she killed your brother, you're out there dating a lot of women through the website," she said. "Doesn't take a genius to join the dots, Jonah."

"I suppose not." He felt the dark sense of suspicion evaporating. It was a fair point—and he still had the strong feeling that Emma could not be a murderer.

Besides—how could he have stumbled onto Nate’s killer on his first date through No Strings? The chances were astronomical.

He said: “You won’t tell anyone, will you?”

“Your secret’s safe with me—I don’t want anyone else knowing I use that website either, you know,” she said. “But how on Earth do you think you’re going to succeed in some madcap search for a killer? By dating every girl in London?”

He chuckled, “If I had to. No—one of the few things I know about Nate is which dating website he used. He told me about it once or twice.”

“Let me guess—No Strings, huh?”

“That’s right.”

“And you expect to date everyone on the website until you run into the killer?”

Jonah sighed. “Well, I had hoped to narrow the field down a little, but I haven’t been able to get into Nate’s account. They won’t send me his log-in details—not even if I pretend I’m him and I forgot my password.”

“That’s what they sell themselves on, isn’t it? Confidentiality. So there’s no possible way a spouse could stumble onto your use of the site.”

“I guess I was pretty stupid to think I could find the killer, huh?”

Emma looked at him, and he thought he detected admiration, or something like it, in her eyes. She said: “It makes you feel you’re contributing, doesn’t it?

Looking for Nate’s killer?”

“If I don’t do something, I just feel so... useless.”

“So what’s the harm? Worst that can happen is you get a load of random dates out of it,” she said, reaching down under the cover now.

As her fingers closed around his flaccid cock, Jonah was a little surprised to find him respond to her touch. Wasn’t it a little soon to be getting

aroused again?

“I suppose you’ve checked Nate’s computer for any clues to his account?” she asked.

“The police have his computer. They’ve told me they examined it in detail but didn’t find anything.”

“They’re not going to give it back?”

“It’s still evidence apparently,” Jonah shrugged. “I could do with it—I have to go to internet cafes to access the website myself. It’s a pain sometimes.”

“You don’t have a computer?”

“Just a poor bumbling Oxford academic,” Jonah smiled. He could tell Emma had noticed him responding physically to her hand groping his cock by now. Hard to miss it swelling in her fingers.

She said: “But your phone will have internet access?”

Jonah shook his head. “One of the few people with a conventional phone, huh?”

Emma tut-tutted at that. She said: “I think you need a personal assistant.”

“A what?”

“A personal assistant,” she said, sitting up. “I have a laptop—I could help you organize your dating. You know—help with your investigation. I’d be like your sidekick.”

Even in the nocturnal gloom, the sight of her stiff little nipples made Jonah’s cock throb into full hardness. “Mmm...he likes the sound of that!” she said, pulling back the covers now to expose Jonah’s erection.

“What, so I’d just hand over control of my account?” he asked.

“Yeah—or I’d just start a new one for you. You know, two accounts searching for the killer might have better luck than one. And I reckon I

might be better at getting you dates than you are. I have inside information.”

“You’d be like my pimp,” Jonah joked. “Wouldn’t girls be put out when my dinner conversation doesn’t match up to your emailing skills on a date?”

Emma now pulled herself up to straddle his hips, sitting back to press her hot pussy on his hardness now. She said: “You forget this isn’t Match.com. They’re not really meeting you for conversation.”

“And you’d just set up dates for me and, what, text me details of where to meet them?”

“Don’t you think it’d be fun?” she grinned, stirring her hips now, to slide her slick folds over his shaft. “I promise not to set you up with any donkeys.”

“And what would you get out of this deal?” he asked her, now gyrating his own hips, feeling a curious sense of power for being able to get hard like this so soon after climax.

“Well, you’d have to promise to tell me everything that happens on your dates,”

she said, “all the filthy details.”

“I could probably handle that.”

“And when you tell me,” she said, slipping the tip of his cock inside her smoldering little pussy, “you’d have to show me as well.”

She suddenly pushed herself down on him, engulfing his hardness in her tight

flesh, and with that he really did gain himself a sidekick.

Nine

It was only three days later that he received a text from Emma stating that she’d fixed him up with a first appointment. It was quick work for a brand new account on the No Strings website, Jonah thought.

He was having a drink with some of Nate's friends from work in the All Bar One close to the Canary Wharf Tube station when she sent him the message bragging that she'd found him "a hottie called Lina". It was the subsequent message that Lina apparently "really enjoyed ordering guys to lick her pussy" that made Jonah nearly choke on his beer.

"You all right there?" Graham, who'd had the desk next to Nate, patted him on the back as though trying to dislodge whatever he'd choked on.

"Sorry—yeah, just got some mad text from someone trying to get me to go out with someone she knows."

"Sounds like a good idea."

Graham was the one who always invited Jonah out for drinks after work whenever Nate's former colleagues were going, and usually Jonah turned him down. He seemed genuinely interested in Jonah's wellbeing, and though Nate had only ever mentioned his work colleagues and Graham in particular on the briefest of occasions, Jonah got the sense that Graham had been good friends with Nate.

"I was thinking of suggesting you go on one of those dating sites like your brother used from time to time," Graham said now, and Jonah noticed him talking under his breath to avoid others overhearing. "Might be a distraction, you know."

Jonah gave him a sharp look. "He told you about that?"

Graham shrugged. "He told me a few things. Had to brag to somebody—and you

were usually holed up in your Oxford college obsessed with a different kind of bird."

Jonah felt a stab of something he initially thought to be envy—perhaps at the spoiling of the illusion that some of Nate's secrets had been revealed only to him. But then he took a deep breath and it became apparent that it was hope he was feeling.

Perhaps Graham would know something that could help.

"D'you... uh... fancy grabbing a little fresh air?" he asked.

“Sure.”

The others thought nothing of Jonah and Graham taking their beers outside—

though the daylight was rapidly fading, there was plenty of artificial light outside the place, which was pedestrianized with tables laid out for customer use.

“Have you told the police about any of this?” he asked as they leaned against the railing overlooking the water of the dock.

“About Nate’s dating habits? Didn’t really think to, really,” Graham said.

“Thought they’d probably have all that info already.”

Jonah shook his head. “They’re after any kind of insight they can get from what I hear. No real leads at the moment.”

“Maybe I’ll give them a call.”

Jonah took a swig of his sharp lager. He said: “Did he tell you much about the women he was going out with?”

Graham shrugged, looking a little sheepish that he hadn’t thought to let the police know what he knew about all this. “He didn’t really tell me that much—

you know, showing off about shagging this girl or that girl. Said they were hot, but not much more than that.”

“I see.” What had been the chances, though, that Nate had opened up about his killer before the repeat date that had ultimately seen him slain?

Graham picked up on the disappointment in Jonah’s voice. It seemed to prompt him: “I mean, some girls he talked about more than others. Towards the end, he was mostly quiet about it. You know what I think?”

“What do you think?”

Graham cast his eyes around them, checking they were out of earshot of anyone else. “I think he had a taste for the married ones.”

Jonah felt the confirmation solidify his recent thinking. “He liked married women?”

Why hadn’t Nate ever said anything about that? Had he thought Jonah might disapprove? He felt a touch of jealousy that his brother would tell Graham something he wouldn’t tell Jonah. But then he felt a little embarrassed at feeling so precious about something like that.

“I got that impression, from a few things he let slip over the last couple of years.

The way he sometimes had to see them at lunch, or last-minute.”

“I guess it meant they wouldn’t expect commitment from him,” Jonah suggested.

“Once, maybe last summer, I remember he was a little drunk one night, and we were talking about girls— he said married women were the best in bed.”

“He did?”

“Like it was the adultery that made it more... explosive.”

“He didn’t ever let slip anything else about the women he went for?”
Jonah felt a new fire igniting within his belly.

“I don’t know,” Graham said. “In the early days, he seemed to get bored of them pretty quick if they were too... docile. You know what I mean?”

“He preferred more dominant women?”

Nate’s old colleague shrugged again, “That’s what I would have said.”

It might not have seemed much to go on, but Jonah felt uplifted somehow, that

he had a few details that confirmed he was venturing down the right track. Nate went for married women, or dominant women, or both.

Graham gulped down the final two fingers of his beer, said: “You think it’s worth telling the police about all this?”

“I’m not sure.” Jonah finished his own beer. “It might be. I mean, was he killed because of his thing for married women? Maybe.”

“I hadn’t thought about it like that.”

“Might not be anything significant. It would make more sense for the husbands to want to come after him, though. The police say the killer was female.”



Emma wasn’t answering when he called her on his brief stroll back home, and he wondered if she was actually out on another date herself. For all their talk of her becoming his ‘sidekick’, assisting with his pursuit via the No Strings website, it felt confusing to him what the status of their relationship was.

It wasn’t really supposed to be about dating, that website. Not beyond the one night stand. And Emma didn’t seem the type to even consider tying herself to one person. Yet Jonah felt as though he hadn’t connected with anyone else quite so well for a long time.

It wasn’t as though he’d been exclusive since seeing her, but it made him feel a little funny inside to think of the pretty blonde being out with some other guy, perhaps someone she’d met on that website. But the truth was, if he suggested to her that they become some kind of item, it would most likely frighten her away.

So, as he crossed the bouncy steel footbridge over the water to West India Quay and his apartment building, Jonah texted Emma instead, telling her that someone else had confirmed that Nate may have had a particular taste for married women.

When he was done texting Emma, which was no easy thing after a few pints of Stella Artois, Jonah stopped to steady himself, and even perhaps avoid falling over and making a fool out of himself. As he stopped, he got the strangest feeling again: the feeling that he was being watched. He turned around, and thought he caught a shadow move over by the Iberica

restaurant. The building had large columns around the lower floor, behind which it would be easy for any skulking figure to lurk.

Jonah felt a chill ripple through his body.

There was nothing he could do. He continued on his way, upping his pace this time, determined to quickly get back to Nate's apartment, where he would feel safe.

Jesus. If a solitary shadow caused him this big a chill, however would he cope if he ever actually caught up with the actual killer?

The elevator opened on the 22 nd floor, and he felt a little better, but his heart was still thumping hard inside his chest. He tapped the code into the door

keypad, and on entering the apartment left the lights off. He went to the windows, keeping close to the wall so that anyone looking in would find it hard to spot him.

He spent a long time peering out into the night, searching every shadow around every building to see if anything moved, if any watcher might figure it was now safe to come out. Other than a few late-night revelers, he could see nothing.

Then he very nearly jumped out of his skin as his mobile phone rang, the little unit in his trouser pocket vibrating suddenly against his thigh.

The number wasn't one in his phone's contact list.

"Hello?"

"Can I speak to Jonah Fielding, please?"

It was a female voice. He did vaguely recognize it. Another chill crept down Jonah's spine.

"Uh... yes? I mean... that's me."

He heard whoever it was take a deep breath, and then say: "I'm sorry for calling so late... I've been meaning to call you all day... just haven't got up the nerve..."

The woman sounded to Jonah as though she was shivering as she spoke. He was racking his brain, but could not think of who he knew she might be. From the way she sounded, Jonah was beginning to feel pity now thawing out his fear.

“How can I help?” he asked.

She said: “It’s Lillian Foster... uh... Lily. We met the other day in the cemetery.

Briefly.”

“Of course, hello Lily,” Jonah felt his heart rate pick up as he registered her identity. “What can I do for you?”

“I didn’t really get a chance to say anything to you,” he heard a faint sniffle from her, the wife of the first hotel victim. “Only, it seems to me you’re the only person I’ve spoken to who truly understands what I’m going through right now.”

“I bet you’ve been going just as crazy trying to make sense of it all as I have.”

“Yes,” the woman said, “yes, it’s all just been whirring round inside my head.

Trying to think of any possible little detail that might help the police.”

“I know what you mean.”

“Mr... Mr Fielding, I...”

“Please, it’s Jonah.”

“Uh... Jonah. I was talking with Detective Inspector Mulray, and she suggested perhaps we meet some time...”

“Absolutely.”

“She said you had a theory, about a dating website.”

“That’s right. I think my brother may have been using a dating website when he died. I think perhaps it’s how he met his killer,” he said. “But the police don’t seem to think there’s any evidence to support the idea. I didn’t think Detective Mulray did, either.”

There was a pause as the woman took in what he had said. Then she said: “I was wondering if I might be able to come and talk to you about it.”

“Of course—any time.” Jonah felt his insides light up—what an opportunity, to talk to someone close to another victim. But he also felt a little confused—why was Mulray interested in having this woman Lily Foster talking to him about the website idea? Hadn’t she all but told him there was nothing in it?

“The thing is,” Lillian Foster said now, “I couldn’t tell the police—but I think my husband may also have been meeting people online before he died.”

A Killer of a One Night Stand In the Next Episode...

Jonah's investigation takes him into the world of consensual extramarital affairs, where husbands and wives know of their partners' infidelities, and even encourage them.

He discovers the truth about Julian Foster, the first of the serial killer's victims, and the strange arrangement the man had with his wife, Lily.

Meanwhile, Jonah must face an increasingly hostile police force unwilling to help him, and unhappy he is getting involved.

And who is following Jonah? The police? The media? Or someone much more dangerous...

Episode Two: Available now at all good e-bookstores web:
MaxSebastian.net/a-killer-of-a-one-night-stand/

A romantic couple is shown in a close embrace on a dark-colored couch. The man, who has a beard and is shirtless, is leaning back against the woman. The woman is wearing a light-colored, short-sleeved top and a white, ribbed, form-fitting skirt. Her hands are resting on the man's neck and shoulder. In the foreground, two glasses of red wine are visible on a dark surface, slightly out of focus. The overall atmosphere is intimate and sensual, with warm lighting.

more hot wives
exploring other men...

4 free erotic stories
when you join the mailing list at:
maxsebastian.net/free

Document Outline

- [Cover Page](#)
- [Cover](#)
- [About the Author](#)
- [Some of Max's Other Books](#)
- [Title Page](#)
- [Copyright](#)
- [Prologue](#)
- [Chapter 1](#)
- [Chapter 2](#)
- [Chapter 3](#)
- [Chapter 4](#)
- [Chapter 5](#)
- [Chapter 6](#)
- [Chapter 7](#)
- [Chapter 8](#)
- [Chapter 9](#)
- [A Killer of a One Night Stand](#)
- [Full Page Image](#)

目录

Cover Page	1
Cover	2
About the Author	3
Some of Max's Other Books	3
Title Page	4
Copyright	4
Prologue	4
Chapter 1	14
Chapter 2	33
Chapter 3	42
Chapter 4	61
Chapter 5	73
Chapter 6	85
Chapter 7	91
Chapter 8	102
Chapter 9	114
A Killer of a One Night Stand	121
Full Page Image	122